The Water at Badr

The Water at Badr

The Battle of Badr, 17 Ramadan 2 AH

Printed for private reading

A note on this edition

The text is a single chapter, set here as a book. It commits in the prose and argues in the notes: a reader who skips every note will meet an unbroken story, and one who reads them will find the disputes set out. The seven narrative sections come first; the apparatus — the weighing of the sources, the contested points, the rosters, the casualty lists, the chronology and the glossary — follows, and then the notes.

Dates are given in the Hijri calendar first, with the Julian equivalent in parentheses. Distances are in miles. A dagger (†) in the lists marks an attribution the sources dispute.

The page is set to Jan Tschichold's golden canon, in which the text block is placed high on the leaf and toward the gutter, with the margins in the proportion 2:3:4:6 — inner, top, outer, bottom — so that the two pages of an opening read as one field. The type is EB Garamond, a revival of the romans cut by Claude Garamond in sixteenth-century Paris, with old-style figures and drawn small capitals; the Arabic glyphs are Amiri.

Contents

The Fodder of Yathrib 1

Three Hundred and Thirteen 6

The Valley of Yalyal 11

The Night of Rain 18

Above the Necks 23

The Pit and the Prisoners 29

What Badr Broke 35

A Note on the Sources 41

What the Sources Disagree About 47

The Principal Figures 57

The Fallen 67

Chronology 73

Numbers and Distances 81

Glossary 83

Further Reading 89

Notes 93

The Fodder of Yathrib

Abu Sufyan ibn Harb crouched at the water of Badr and broke a lump of camel dung apart in his fingers. There were date-stones in it. He stood up and said, to nobody in particular, that this was the fodder of Yathrib.[1]

He had been asking after riders all the way down the coast, at every well and of every man he met, and at Badr a local of Juhayna named Majdi ibn ʻAmr had told him that two strangers had couched their camels on the rise above the water, filled a skin, and gone again. Majdi thought nothing of them. Abu Sufyan, who had spent the whole return leg expecting to be hunted, thought a great deal of them: dates were what a man of the Medinan oasis fed his beast, and a beast fed on Medinan dates had a Medinan rider. He turned the caravan off the inland road that night and drove it west, out onto the dry coastal strip between Badr and the sea, past the wells and past the men waiting at them.[2]

The two riders had come from Muhammad's town, and they had come looking for him.

Yathrib lay some two hundred and fifty miles north of Mecca: not a city in any sense a Roman or a Persian would have recognised, but a wide oasis of date-palms and barley plots and walled compounds strung along a basalt plain, each cluster with its own wells and its own armed men. Its Arab population was two large tribes, Aws and Khazraj, who had been fighting each other within living memory; three Jewish tribes farmed and traded there and

held the best land in parts of it. Into this the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ had come in Rabi' al-Awwal of the year 1 (the late summer of 622), with something under a hundred Meccan families, at the invitation of men of Aws and Khazraj who wanted, among other things, an arbiter.

The Meccans who came with him were the Muhajirun, the emigrants — men and women who had left a mercantile city where they held property, credit and standing, and arrived in an agricultural one where they held none of these things and did not know how to farm. Those who took them in were the Ansar, the helpers: the Aws and Khazraj households that lodged them, married them, and in a number of cases split their palm-groves with them. What the emigrants had left behind did not stay behind. Houses in Mecca were occupied, debts written off in the debtor's favour, and goods and shares turned over to those who remained; Ibn Ishaq notes without comment that the house of one emigrant was sold by his own kin.[3] Capital in Mecca did not sit still. It went north with the caravans. A man in Medina in the spring of the year 2 could stand near enough to the road to watch, in the abstract at least, the proceeds of his own confiscated stock going past him as somebody else's cargo.

That road was the reason Mecca existed. The town had no crops and almost no water; it lived on the sanctuary, on the pilgrim traffic, and above all on the two-way carrying trade between the Yemen and Syria — hides, leather, raisins, silver, incense going north; textiles, oil, worked metal, weapons and wheat coming south. A single camel carried something like three hundred pounds, and a load of Syrian cloth or plate might be worth what an ordinary man could earn in years. The trade was not incidental to Quraysh; it was the substance of the place, financed by shares taken up across the clans, so that a caravan of any size on that road belonged, in fractions, to nearly everybody.[4]

Medina's position with respect to that road was the whole of its leverage. The coastal trunk route from Mecca to Syria ran up the Hijaz west of the mountains, and at its nearest — in the neighbourhood of Badr — it passed within about eighty miles of the oasis: three or four days out for a party of riders, near enough to reach the road, take what was on it, and be home inside a fortnight. Whether that leverage was ever exercised as a deliberate squeeze on Meccan food is a question modern historians have argued more sharply than the sources do, but the Meccans themselves plainly understood what the oasis was now sitting beside.[5]

None of this was new in Ramadan of 2 AH. For something over a year small parties had been going out from Medina towards the road and coming back with nothing. In the autumn the Prophet himself led men to Waddan, near al-Abwa', and found no caravan; in the following month Hamza ibn 'Abd al-Muttalib or 'Ubayda ibn al-Harith — the reports vary as to which expedition was whose — went towards the coast; in the spring there was Buwat, and after it al-'Ushayra in the valley of Yanbu', where the Prophet took some hundred and fifty men down to the sea and arrived days after Abu Sufyan's caravan had gone through on its way north. That was the same cargo, missed on its outward leg. Then in Safar a Fihri raider named Kurz ibn Jabir lifted grazing camels from the pastures outside Medina and was chased as far as Safawan, in the country of Badr, and lost. Five approaches to the same stretch of road in a year, and not one of them had produced a fight.[6]

One had produced a death. In Rajab, seven or eight men under 'Abdallah ibn Jahsh — sent out with sealed orders, on the reports, and told not to open them for two days — came upon a small Qurayshi caravan at Nakhla, between Mecca and al-Ta'if, carrying raisins, leather and wine. They took it, and in taking it they shot 'Amr ibn al-Hadrami dead. The trouble was the month. Rajab was one of the sacred months in which Arab custom forbade fighting,

and Mecca had a genuine grievance to broadcast: that Muhammad's men had shed blood in a truce month at the edge of the sanctuary. Ibn Ishaq reports that the Prophet withheld the spoils and the prisoners at first, and was displeased with the raiders.[7] The Hadrami blood-claim did not go away. It was still unpaid when Quraysh next had occasion to count it up, and it would count then.

Abu Sufyan's caravan left Gaza for the south some time in the middle weeks of the winter, a thousand camels or thereabouts under the charge of perhaps thirty or forty armed men, carrying the pooled trading capital of the Meccan houses.[8] It was a merchant's escort and not a war-party; the caravan's protection was speed and the choice of road. A loaded caravan on good ground made perhaps twenty-five miles in a day, which put the Badr latitude — the last open stretch before the road bent inland for Mecca — somewhere in the second week of Ramadan.

Medina knew roughly when to expect it, and the Prophet sent two of the emigrants north to sit on the road and make sure: Talha ibn 'Ubaydallah and Sa'id ibn Zayd, who went up to the neighbourhood of al-Hawra' on the coast and lay up there with a man of Juhayna until the caravan came down past them. Then they turned their camels and rode for Medina with the news that Abu Sufyan was on the road and coming south.[9]

It was Ramadan, the month of the fast, when a man ate and drank nothing between first light and sunset; the Muslims of Medina had been keeping it for a little over a year, and they would fight in it. Ramadan of that year fell in March. The heat was not yet the killing heat of high summer, but the winter rains were finished or nearly so, the grazing was drying off, and the wells along the road were at the level where a large body of men and animals could water at only a few of them. The oasis itself could put very little into the field in the

way of equipment. When the count was made there were two horses in the whole force.

Two horses, and a fortnight's food, and a march to a stretch of open country where a thousand camels would be strung out over a mile of road under thirty or forty guards. What was being got ready in Medina was an interception, of the kind that had been attempted four or five times already and had four or five times come to nothing — a raid on property, mounted against men who were not expecting to be fought and who could be expected, if they were caught at a disadvantage, to give up the cargo and save themselves. Nothing in the preparations answers to an army. The tradition itself, which had every reason afterwards to present the day as appointed from the beginning, does not pretend otherwise: the Qur'an would remind the believers that what they had wanted was the easier of two things, and Ibn Ishaq's account of the muster is an account of men called out for a caravan.[10] What they would meet in the valley of Badr twelve days later nobody in the oasis had in mind that afternoon, because it did not yet exist as anybody's plan, in Medina or in Mecca.

The order went round Medina that afternoon, and it was not an order to prepare for a battle.

Three Hundred and Thirteen

Damdam ibn ʻAmr al-Ghifari came into the valley of Mecca on a camel whose ears he had slit and whose nose he had bloodied, standing in his saddle, his shirt turned back to front. Abu Sufyan had hired him on the road north and sent him down the coast at speed, three hundred miles and more, to say one thing in the one form nobody in the city could mistake. The mutilated beast, the reversed saddle, the torn and inverted garment: each was a recognised sign of catastrophe, and together they meant that a man had ridden past the point of caring for his property or his dignity. Ibn Ishaq has him cry it out in front of the Ka'ba: "O Quraysh, the merchandise! Abu Sufyan is with it, and Muhammad and his companions have cut him off. I do not think you will reach it. Help! Help!"[11]

Three nights earlier, by the account Ibn Ishaq gives, ʻAtika bint ʻAbd al-Muttalib had woken frightened and sent for her brother al-ʻAbbas. She had seen a rider come into the valley on a camel, she said, and halt, and cry three times: "Set out, O treacherous people, to your deaths in three days." The people gathered to him. Then he was on the roof of the Ka'ba crying the same words, and then on the shoulder of Abu Qubays, the mountain over the town, crying them a third time; and then he took up a boulder and loosed it down the slope, and it broke as it came, and there was not a house or a dwelling in Mecca that did not have a fragment of it inside. Al-ʻAbbas repeated the dream and it went round the town. Abu Jahl heard it and jeered: another prophetess among the sons of ʻAbd al-Muttalib, and if nothing had

happened in three days they would be written down as the greatest liars in the sanctuary. On the third day Damdam rode in. Al-'Abbas found Abu Jahl at the Ka'ba as the clans were arming, and said, "This is what she saw."[12]

Mecca was on the road inside two days. There was nothing improvised about the shape of the muster and everything improvised about its purpose: each clan of Quraysh sent its men behind its own banner, and a man who would not go was expected to pay for a substitute, so that staying at home cost either money or standing.[13] Old debts were suspended and old feuds set aside to get the column out. Nine or ten of the great men undertook to feed the whole army by turns, each taking a day and slaughtering camels for it — an ostentation that would later tell the Muslims almost exactly how many mouths were in the valley. The column went out with drums, with singing-women in it to abuse the enemy in verse, with a hundred horses led at the front and flanks, and with mail and shields in quantity: al-Waqidi, whose figures for equipment run into the hundreds, is describing a force that could put an armoured man into the line wherever it chose.[14]

Two absences are worth as much as the muster. Abu Lahab, uncle to the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ and one of the loudest of his enemies, did not go. He had a claim of four thousand dirhams against al-'As ibn Hisham ibn al-Mughira, who was bankrupt, and he sent al-'As out in his place in settlement of the debt — a man's body against a sum of silver, which is the plainest statement anywhere in the sources of what the levy was worth in cash.[15] The whole clan of Banu 'Adi ibn Ka'b, 'Umar ibn al-Khattab's people, sent nobody at all, and were neither shamed into it nor apparently much pressed; no blood of 'Adi was shed on either side at Badr.[16]

Where shame was applied it worked. Umayya ibn Khalaf of Banu Jumah, heavy and elderly and among the first men of Mecca, had decided to stay. 'Uqba ibn Abi Mu'ayt came to him where he sat among his people carrying a

censer of burning incense and a kohl-stick, set them down in front of him, and told him to perfume himself and paint his eyes, for he was one of the women. It was the most direct insult available in that society, and it was delivered in public, in front of the men whose regard was the whole of Umayya's position. He answered, "God curse you and what you have brought," bought the fastest camel in Mecca, armed himself, and marched.[17]

The other column had gone out first, and it had gone out smaller. The Prophet left Medina on 12 Ramadan with three hundred and thirteen men — the number the tradition has kept and repeated more consistently than any other figure of the day, and the one I follow — of whom something over eighty were Muhajirun and the rest Ansar of Aws and Khazraj.[18] They had two horses. Al-Zubayr ibn al-'Awwam rode one and al-Miqdad ibn 'Amr the other, and there was no third; against the hundred coming up from Mecca this was not cavalry but two mounted messengers. They had about seventy camels for three hundred and thirteen men, which meant three and sometimes four to a beast, each riding his stage and then walking while the others rode, in the last third of a fasting month, on a road going south-west into rising heat. There were six coats of mail in the army and eight swords.[19] Everyone else carried a bow, a spear, a staff, or stones.

The Prophet took his place in the rotation. He shared a camel with 'Ali ibn Abi Talib and Marthad ibn Abi Marthad al-Ghanawi, and when they offered him the whole ride he refused it: he was no stronger than they, he said, and no less in need of the reward.[20] Mus'ab ibn 'Umayr carried the white standard at the head of the column, 'Ali the black banner called al-'Uqab, the Eagle, and al-Hubab ibn al-Mundhir of Khazraj the second black banner, that of the Ansar. Ibn Umm Maktum, who was blind, was left to lead the prayer in the city; at al-Rawha', a day out, Abu Lubaba ibn 'Abd al-Mundhir was turned back to hold Medina itself. Boys who had attached themselves to the column

were sent home. It was an expedition of the ordinary kind, aimed at a caravan of about a thousand camels coming down the coast, and it was not equipped for anything else.

The news reached them in the valley of Dhafiran, four days out and perhaps twenty miles short of Badr: that Quraysh had marched from Mecca in force to defend the caravan. What followed there is the most consequential half-hour of the campaign, and it happened in talk. Ibn Ishaq has the Prophet lay the changed position before the men and ask them plainly for their counsel — "Advise me, O people" — which is not the act of a commander who considered the matter settled, and not the shape a later writer would have given the scene if he were free to invent it.[21] Abu Bakr spoke, and spoke for going on. 'Umar spoke to the same effect. Then al-Miqdad ibn 'Amr stood up for the emigrants and said that they would not say what the Children of Israel said to Moses — go you and your Lord and fight — but rather, go, and we fight with you; if he led them to Bark al-Ghimad, at the far end of the world as they reckoned it, they would go with him to it.

And the Prophet asked again for counsel.

He was waiting for the Ansar, and everybody present understood why. The men of Aws and Khazraj had pledged themselves at 'Aqaba to protect him in their own town, as they protected their own children — a compact of sanctuary, not of campaign. Nothing in it obliged them to march four days into the desert and stand against the assembled clans of Quraysh, and two-thirds of the column were Ansar. Sa'd ibn Mu'adh, chief of Aws, saw what the repeated question meant and said so: it seemed the Prophet meant them. He was told yes. Ibn Ishaq's report of what Sa'd answered has the cadence of something remembered rather than composed: they had believed him and borne witness that what he brought was true and given their oaths to obey; let him go where he wished and they were with him; and by Him who sent him,

if he went down into the sea they would go into it with him, and not one of them would stay behind.[22] It was consent given by men who could have refused on the letter of an agreement, and it converted a raiding party into an army by the only means available.

What it did not do was decide who they would meet. The Qur'an is unusually direct about this, and it is the earliest layer of evidence there is: Surat al-Anfal, addressing the believers afterwards, recalls that God had promised them one of the two parties and that they had wanted the other of the two — the unarmed one, the one with the camels and the cloth on it — while God intended to establish the truth and cut off the unbelievers.[23] The passage is a rebuke of a preference, and a rebuke only makes sense if the preference was real. Three hundred and thirteen men had come out for a caravan. They had just agreed to go on if the alternative was forced on them; they had not agreed to seek it, and nobody at Dhafiran proposed marching on the Meccan army where it stood. They went forward towards the water.

Two columns were now on the road, and each of them was still looking for something other than the other.

The Valley of Yalyal

The plain of Badr lay about eighty miles south-west of Medina, where the caravan road from Syria bent inland from the sea. It was not a valley in the sense a reader in a wet country would understand, but a wadi — a watercourse that carries water only after rain and is dry sand the rest of the year — and the wadi at Badr was called Yalyal. It gathered the run-off of the highlands behind Medina and swung away west-north-west toward the Red Sea, dying in the coastal sands short of the shore. Through the battlefield it ran not in one channel but in three or four braided ones, a few paces wide and knee-deep: nothing that would stop a man, but enough that a rank crossing one came out of it untidy.[24]

The floor at Badr was an open bowl, perhaps two miles long and a mile across where the ground was flat enough to stand an army on, closed by dark rock on the north and east, by broken rocky ground on the south, and on the west by a single great wall of sand. There was no water on the surface. What made Badr worth a name was that the water lay in the sand four or five fathoms down, shallow enough to reach with a hand-dug shaft and a leather bucket, and men had dug there: seven or eight wells strung along the north-eastern edge of the floor, with date-palms and walled plots behind them. In the middle of March, at the tail of the winter rains, there was no other reliable water within a day's march in any direction, and both armies knew it before either arrived.[25]

The wall of sand on the western side was al-ʻAqanqal, and it decided the day. It ran for over a mile, its crest sixty to ninety feet above the floor, and it was a dune and not a rock ridge with sand on it: the back slope, on the Mecca side, was gentle enough to walk a column up; the inner face was a slip-face of loose red sand standing at thirty degrees. Beneath it lay a belt of low dunes and hollows a third of a mile deep, the only ground on which a force coming up the Mecca road could form. The eastern side, where the wells were, was different in kind — packed sand over gravel, firm in any weather, with a gravel gap between the hills through which the Medina track came down. The Qur'an later fixed the geometry in two phrases, the nearer bank and the farther bank, the nearer being nearer to Medina.[26] Sight-lines ran a mile, so whichever army arrived second would be seen arriving.

The Prophet Muhammad ﷺ had sent two men of Juhayna ahead to the water days before, Basbas ibn ʻAmr and ʻAdi ibn Abi'l-Zaghba', local men who could sit at a Badr well without being strangers, and they had brought back the caravan's timing from two women quarrelling over a debt. Now, on the night of the sixteenth of Ramadan, he sent ʻAli ibn Abi Talib, al-Zubayr ibn al-ʻAwwam and Sa'd ibn Abi Waqqas down to the wells to lie up and wait. They took two men who came for water, slaves of the Meccan army sent with skins, one named Aslam.[27]

The first questioning went badly, and the sources preserve it going badly. The Muslims, still hoping for a caravan, asked where Abu Sufyan was; the two said they were water-carriers of Quraysh; the Muslims disbelieved them and beat them until they said what was wanted, which was that they were Abu Sufyan's men. Ibn Ishaq has the Prophet come over from his prayer and tell his own men that they had beaten the two for telling the truth and let them alone for lying.[28] Then he put his own questions. Where were Quraysh? Behind that hill, at al-ʻAqanqal. How many? Many. How many exactly? They

did not know. How many camels did they slaughter in a day? One day nine, the next day ten.

That was the count, because a slaughtered camel fed roughly a hundred men for a day, and any Arab who had provisioned a raiding party knew the conversion. Ibn Ishaq has the Prophet say it aloud: they were between nine hundred and a thousand men. It is a figure that arrives with its working shown, which is why this account prefers it, at roughly nine hundred and fifty, to the round thousand of the later tradition.[29] He asked next which of the great men were with them, and the two named them off: 'Utba ibn Rabi'a and his brother Shayba, Abu Jahl, Umayya ibn Khalaf, Suhayl ibn 'Amr, al-Nadr ibn al-Harith, Zam'a ibn al-Aswad, Nubayh and Munabbih the sons of al-Hajjaj, Hakim ibn Hizam. The Prophet turned to his companions and said that Mecca had thrown to them the choicest pieces of her own liver.

Against those nine hundred and fifty stood three hundred and thirteen. Quraysh had a hundred horses and seven hundred camels; the Muslims two horses and about seventy camels ridden in turns. That the Meccan column had brought its drummers and its singing-women down that road is a fair indication of what the men who organised the march expected to have to do at the end of it.[30]

What they had come out to do was already done, and done without them. Abu Sufyan had turned his caravan hard west onto the dry coastal strip and run it south through the night without a watering halt, twenty or thirty miles seaward of the wadi. From the coast he sent a rider back to the column: they had come out to protect their caravan, their men and their goods, God had delivered them, and they should go home.[31]

The column, at that point, began to turn round. A story in which the Meccan army was already withdrawing when it was talked back into a battle it then lost does nothing for anybody's theology — it makes the victory of the

seventeenth a victory over men who had not wanted to be there — and it survives for no better reason than that it happened. What stopped the turn was a debt. Some months earlier, at Nakhla, a raiding party of Muhammad's had killed a Meccan client named ʻAmr ibn al-Hadrami in a month in which fighting was forbidden; the blood was never settled. Ibn Ishaq has Abu Jahl refuse the withdrawal outright: they would not go back, he said, until they had been to Badr, where they would halt three days, slaughter camels, feast, pour wine and let the Arabs hear of it, so that the Arabs would fear them for ever.[32]

That answer explains why Quraysh marched and why they marched on after the reason for marching had gone. The caravan brought them out of Mecca; what kept them on the road once it was safe was the road itself. A town that lived by moving other men's goods along a corridor eight hundred miles long could not afford to be seen chased off it, and the Arabs whose good behaviour that corridor depended on were watching.[33] Abu Jahl's three days of feasting were not bluster. They were the purpose of the expedition once the caravan was out of it.

Not everyone accepted it. At the halt where Abu Sufyan's rider reached them, al-Akhnas ibn Shariq, the Thaqafi confederate who spoke for Banu Zuhra, put it to his people that the caravan was safe, that Zuhra had no claim in the Hadrami blood, and that nothing was to be got by marching on Medina; and he took them home. Not one man of Banu Zuhra was at Badr, and al-Akhnas was afterwards reckoned the most fortunate man in Quraysh.[34] Banu ʻAdi ibn Kaʼb sent nobody at all, and Banu Hashim and Banu al-Muttalib came unwillingly and under pressure. The army that came over al-ʻAqanqal was smaller than the army that had left Mecca, and it was already an army that had argued.

It argued once more at the last halt short of the ridge. ʻUtba ibn Rabiʼa of ʻAbd Shams was the senior man of Quraysh on the ground, over sixty, and he did not want the battle. He mounted a red camel and rode along the front of his own people telling them they would gain nothing by fighting Muhammad and his companions: if they killed him, every man among them would afterwards be looking into the face of a cousin he had killed. Better to leave him to the other Arabs. And — the offer that mattered, because it removed the last legal ground for the war — he would pay the blood-money for ʻAmr ibn al-Hadrami himself, blood-money being the compensation in camels or coin that settled a killing between clans and closed the claim.[35]

He sent Hakim ibn Hizam, a nephew of Khadija and a moderate, round the chiefs with the proposal, and Hakim found them willing. Then he took it to Abu Jahl, who was oiling his coat of mail, and Abu Jahl said that ʻUtbaʼs lungs had swelled up when he saw how few the Muslims were, and that his own son was among them and he was afraid for him.

Then Abu Jahl sent for ʻAmir ibn al-Hadrami, the dead manʼs brother, and told him his ally wanted to go home with his revenge in front of his eyes, and he had better get up and call for his dead. ʻAmir got up, uncovered himself, threw dust on his head and cried out for ʻAmr — the formal cry of the unavenged, which no man of standing could hear and walk away from. The proposal died there. Abu Jahl finished it by calling ʻUtba a coward, and ʻUtba called for a helmet, could find none in the camp large enough for his head, and bound a cloth round it instead.

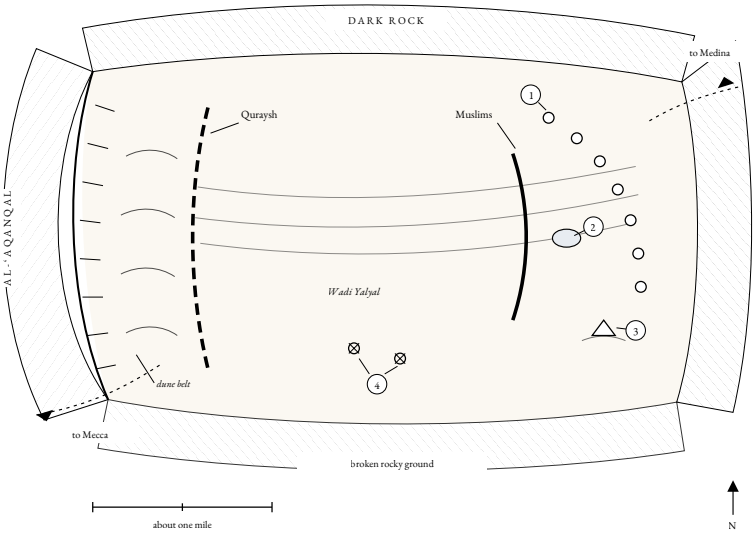
On the eastern side of the wadi that same evening, the Muslims came down through the gravel gap and halted short of the wells, and al-Hubab ibn al-Mundhir, an Ansari of Banu Salima, came to the Prophet and asked the question that made the difference. Was this a place God had ordered him to occupy, so that they might neither go forward from it nor fall back, or was it a

matter of opinion and stratagem of war? It was opinion and stratagem of war. Then, said al-Hubab, this was not the place: take the army forward to the well nearest the enemy, camp on it, fill in the wells beyond, and dig a cistern and fill it, so that the Muslims would fight and drink and Quraysh would fight without drinking. Ibn Ishaq reports that the Prophet accepted the advice and moved the army before dark.[36]

The exchange is also evidence of how the men around Muhammad understood him: such a question could be asked out loud and answered without offence. What it produced was a camp astride the water. The Muslims drank, watered their camels, filled their skins, and puddled the floor of a basin a few paces across and filled that too — a dark pool of standing water two hundred paces behind where their line would stand. The wells nearest the Mecca approach were broken in and filled with sand.[37]

Quraysh, coming up the Mecca road as the light went, had to cross the ridge; the alternative was to fight for water they could not see against an enemy already standing on it. They walked their column up the gentle back of al-ʻAqanqal and brought it down the slip-face, men and horses and seven hundred camels, into the dune belt at the bottom, the tail of it still coming over the crest after dark. Descending loose sand at thirty degrees is bad going for a man and worse for a horse, which cannot see its footing, breaks the crust, and slides on its hocks; a hundred horses came down that face in the failing light, and their riders put them to no use next day that any source records.[38] The Meccans came off the sand into the hollows of the far bank having drunk last on the road, three-quarters of a mile from the wells, the whole Muslim army between them and a drink.

By the time the sun went down on the sixteenth of Ramadan, the Muslims had the water behind them and Quraysh had a sandhill at their backs.



① the wells, seven or eight of them · ② the *hawd*, the cistern dug and filled on al-Hubab's advice · ③ the *ʿarish*, the shelter of palm branches · ④ wells broken in and filled with sand

The floor at Badr, looking down. A schematic drawn from the descriptions in Ibn Ishaq and al-Waqidi, not a survey: the distances are the ones the sources give and the shapes are indicative only. The Muslims held the firm nearer bank with the wells, the cistern and the shelter behind them. Quraysh walked their column over the wall of sand at al-ʿAqanqal and spent the night in the hollows of the farther bank, three-quarters of a mile from a drink, with the whole Muslim army between them and the water.

The Night of Rain

It rained in the night. It was the middle of March, the tail of the season when squalls come off the Red Sea and cross the coastal plain in an hour, and it fell across the whole valley. What it did to the two banks had already been decided by the banks themselves. The loose red sand under al-'Aqanqal, where Quraysh were camped, took the water and slumped; the flatter gravel and silt of the Medinan side compacted under it and set hard.[39] Men on one bank woke to mud that pulled at the foot. Men on the other woke to a surface they could run on.

The Muslims slept. Ibn Ishaq, whose account of the expedition comes down to us in Ibn Hisham's edition of the *Sirat Rasul Allah*, reports that a deep and easy drowsiness came over the camp that night, and that men who had every reason to lie awake — three hundred of them, eighty miles from home, with something on the order of nine hundred and fifty of their own tribesmen and neighbours across the wadi — lay down beside their weapons and slept soundly until the call to prayer. Surat al-Anfal names the sleep and tells the believers what it was: a security sent down upon them from God, and water sent down from the sky to purify them, to take away the whisperings of Satan and to make firm their feet.[40] The Prophet Muhammad ﷺ did not sleep.

Sa'd ibn Mu'adh had seen to the shelter before dark. It was an 'arish — a rough booth of palm branches, the kind a man makes for shade at a well — and the working party of Ansar raised it on a low rise a hundred and fifty

paces or so behind the centre of the line, high enough that a man standing in its mouth could see the whole frontage and the pass beyond it. Sa'd posted a guard of his own people around it. He also had riding camels kept saddled and kneeling beside it, and Ibn Ishaq has him say why: if God gave them the victory, that was what they wanted; and if the day went the other way, the Prophet would reach his own people in Medina, and behind him there were men who loved him no less than the three hundred who had come out.[41] It was not a comfortable thing to say the night before a battle, and later writers were uneasy enough with it to drop the camels.

He prayed most of the night standing by the trunk of a tree beside the shelter, and towards the end of it he raised both hands towards the qibla and did not lower them. The wording of what he said varies from report to report; the shortest and earliest form of it, which Bukhari preserves from Ibn 'Abbas, is the one to hold: "O God, fulfil for me what You have promised me. O God, if this band perishes this day, You will not be worshipped on the earth."[42] He pressed it so long that the cloak slipped from his shoulders and lay on the ground behind him. Abu Bakr was in the mouth of the shelter with a drawn sword. He came in, picked up the cloak, put it back across the Prophet's shoulders, took him by the hand, and told him that this was enough — that he had pressed his Lord long enough, and that God would give him what He had promised.

The night of 16–17 Ramadan 2 AH (12–13 March 624) ended at about a quarter past five. The seventeenth is the date this chapter follows, and it fell on a Friday.[43] Bilal called the prayer from the front of the camp and the army formed up in ranks to pray, armed, in the order in which it was going to fight. The tradition is divided about whether they fasted that day; most probably they did, no leave to break the fast on the march having yet been given.[44] Then the Prophet walked the length of the line — a front of about a hundred and

twenty paces, which is what three hundred men in three ranks come to — and told them to be patient, not to break the ranks and not to begin anything before the word was given, and that no man of them would meet the enemy that day and be killed pressing forward, not turning back, but God would bring him into the Garden.

He dressed the line himself, with an arrow-shaft in his hand, using it the way a man uses a rod to sight along a row and push a shoulder back into it. Al-Waqidi, whose *Kitab al-Maghazi* is the fullest source for the ground and the small business of that morning, has him press the shaft into the belly of Sawad ibn Ghaziyya, who was standing out in front of his place in the rank. It hurt. Sawad said so: God had sent him with truth and justice, and he wanted his redress. The Prophet uncovered his own belly and told him to take it. Sawad bent, put his arms round him and kissed the place, and when he was asked what he had meant by it said that he had wanted his last act in this world to be that.[45] Before he went back to the shelter he walked out into the empty ground between the armies and marked with the shaft the patches of sand on which particular men of Quraysh would fall, naming them: 'Utba, Shayba, al-Walid, Abu Jahl, Umayya ibn Khalaf, al-Nadr ibn al-Harith.[46]

Three hundred and thirteen men stood in line in a fasting month with eight swords among them.

Quraysh came out of the dunes in the first hour after sunrise — between about half past six and seven, by the reckoning set out in the Chronology — up out of the hollows they had spent the night in and onto the open floor. The image the sources reach for is of sand-hills on the move, a broad dark mass sliding down the last of the long slope, and what the reports also preserve is that the ground was working against them from the first step: the rain-soaked sand slid and gave under hoof and heel, and men came onto the flat already blown. They deployed on a frontage rather wider than the Muslim

one, overlapping both flanks, the horses divided between the wings, al-Nadr ibn al-Harith carrying the standard in the centre, the baggage and the camels parked behind them at the dune's foot. The sun, coming up over the eastern shoulder of the valley, was in their faces.

From the mouth of the shelter the Prophet watched them form up and raised his hands again. Ibn Ishaq gives the words: here were Quraysh, come in their vanity and their pride, calling His Messenger a liar; and he asked for the help he had been promised, and asked that they be brought low that morning.[47] Down the Muslim line the watchword passed from man to man, one word repeated — *ahad*, one — and the line did not move.

The first man across the gap went for the water. Al-Aswad ibn 'Abd al-Asad al-Makhzumi was a quarrelsome man with a reputation for it, and he came out of the Qurayshi right alone, running, on an oath that he would drink from the Muslims' cistern or destroy it or die in front of it. Hamza ibn 'Abd al-Muttalib stepped out of the Muslim right to meet him at the cistern's edge and took his leg off below the knee with one stroke. Al-Aswad fell, and then dragged himself forward on his hands into the basin to get at the water and keep the first clause of his oath, and Hamza came down after him and killed him in it.[48] The whole thing occupied a minute and happened off the axis of the battle, at the edge of the field, over a cistern.

Then the formal part began. An Arab battle opened, where both sides consented to it, with *mubaraza* — single combats fought out in the gap between the lines, champion against champion, while the armies stood and watched — and out of the Qurayshi right came three men of one house: 'Utba ibn Rabi'a, his brother Shayba ibn Rabi'a, and 'Utba's son al-Walid ibn 'Utba. They stood in the open and called for men of their own standing. Three young men of the Ansar answered first: 'Awf and Mu'awwidh, the sons of 'Afra, and 'Abdallah ibn Rawaha. They named themselves, and were told to

go back — the Quraysh had no business with them and wanted their equals, from their own kin. Ibn Ishaq's sequence, which I follow, has the herald of Quraysh then call across to the Muslim line for peers out of the tribe, and the Prophet send the three Ansar back to their exact places in the rank.[49]

He called three men of his own house out instead, by name: stand up, 'Ubayda ibn al-Harith; stand up, Hamza; stand up, 'Ali. They walked out and named their fathers, and the Quraysh acknowledged them as worthy. 'Ubayda, the eldest and heaviest of the three, took 'Utba; Hamza took Shayba; 'Ali, the youngest man in the gap, took al-Walid. Two of the three pairs were finished almost at once. Hamza cut Shayba down and Shayba did not get up. 'Ali gave al-Walid no time at all. The third pair, the two old men, fought on and wounded each other, and then 'Utba's sword took 'Ubayda's leg from under him and he went down where he stood. Hamza and 'Ali turned from their own dead and closed on 'Utba together and killed him over his body.

They carried 'Ubayda back on a cloak, ninety paces to the line and up the rise to the shelter, and the Prophet laid his head on his own foot. Ibn Ishaq has him say, of the poetry Abu Talib had once made in defence of the family, that if his uncle could see him now he would know that he himself had the better right to have said it. The marrow showed in the stump. He died of the wound days later at al-Safra' on the road home and was buried there.[50] Of the three men who had walked out of the Qurayshi right, all three were dead inside half an hour, and they were a father, an uncle and a son of one of the two or three first houses of Mecca. A ripple went along the Qurayshi right that everyone in both armies could see.

Then the lines closed, and after that nobody could see the whole of it.

Above the Necks

The Muslims did not move. The order had gone down the line before the Quraysh were within a bowshot, and it was an order about restraint rather than about attack: keep the ranks, shoot if they press close, and do not draw a sword until they are upon you.[51] Ibn Ishaq gives it in that form, and it has the shape of something remembered rather than composed, because it is tactically unglamorous and it fits the ground. They stood on the firm, rain-packed sand of the near bank with the water behind them, and the Quraysh had to come to them across the churned soft going in front of the dunes. Every minute the Muslim line held was a minute the larger army spent walking in sand with the sun coming up in its eyes.

So the first phase of Badr was not a charge but an exchange of arrows across a closing gap, and the first Muslims to die that day died of it. Mihja', a freedman of 'Umar ibn al-Khattab, was hit and killed before the lines touched; al-Waqidi, who is fullest on the ground at Badr, puts Harith ibn Suraqa of the Ansar at the cistern behind the line, struck through while he drank.[52] Sa'd ibn Abi Waqqas shot from the second rank until his own arrows were gone, and then gathered spent Qurayshi shafts out of the sand and shot them back.

What the eight swords and six coats of mail meant in practice governed everything that followed.[53] The Muslims fought with spears, with bows, with stones out of the wadi bed, and with their hands. A sword at Badr was the property of a rich man or a lucky one, and the sources treat individual blades

the way they treat the two horses: they name the man who carried a particular weapon and they record it as an event when one broke, which would be pointless in an army that had weapons to spare. The Quraysh had come out equipped as an army: mail, helmets, horses, and coats of plate on the men in the middle of their line.

Ibn Ishaq reports that when the two masses were near enough for the dust of the Qurayshi advance to be blowing across the gap, the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ came down from the shelter, took up a handful of the valley's gravel and dust, and threw it towards the Quraysh, saying: "Let the faces be disfigured."[54] The report goes on that the dust went into their eyes and mouths along the whole front, and that the advance staggered. Then came the word the line had been waiting for, and the three hundred went forward off the hard ground at a run, calling out the single word "One! One!" — and the two armies met near the middle of the valley floor.

What the Qur'an tells the believers about the next hour is not a description of it. Surat al-Anfal speaks to them of a thousand of the angels, rank on rank, sent down as help and as a token, and of a command given over their heads: "I am with you, so strengthen those who believe. I shall cast terror into the hearts of those who disbelieve; so strike above the necks, and strike off their fingertips."[55] It is allusive, addressed to men who had been there and did not need the scene set. The narrative sources, coming a century and more later, filled it in.

Ibn Ishaq preserves a report from an Ansari of the Banu Mazin who said that he was chasing a man of the Quraysh in front of him when he heard, above the noise, the crack of a whip and a rider's voice crying "Forward, Hayzum!" — and the man he was chasing fell dead before he reached him; when he told the Prophet, he was told that this was help from the third heaven. Muslim has the same account by way of Ibn 'Abbas.[56] Al-Waqidi col-

lects others: men who found their strongest opponents going down to strokes from nowhere, heads falling with no swordsman behind them, and a sound in the air like stones dropped into a brass basin. In the later material the help acquires faces, names and uniforms — angels in the likeness of al-Zubayr ibn al-'Awwam, who wore a yellow turban that day, so that the sign of the help was his headgear.[57] That growth is itself instructive, and the reports are set out in the notes for what they are: what men of the next generations said the men of Badr had said they heard.

The dust is also the reason no detailed account of the middle of the battle can be trusted. Some thirteen hundred men and a hundred horses were trampling a valley floor whose top inch the sun had already taken back off the night's rain; within minutes of the lines meeting, nobody on the field could see more than the men immediately around him. A melee of that kind has no shape to recover. What the sources preserve instead — and preserve very well, because each of them came down in the family of the man it concerned — is a set of episodes: this man, on this piece of ground, doing this. The honest way to give the battle is to move through them.

'Ukkasha ibn Mihsan, of the Muhajirun, fought until his sword broke off in his hand. He went back through the ranks to the Prophet, who gave him a dry palm-branch and told him to fight with that; and Ibn Ishaq reports that when he shook it, it became a long white blade, and that he went back into the press with it and it opened the line in front of him. He kept it, and called it al-'Awn, the Aid, and carried it in every battle afterwards until he was killed years later in the wars of the apostasy; and the sword stayed in his family for generations after that.[58]

Abu Jahl — 'Amr ibn Hisham of the Banu Makhzum, who had shamed the Meccan column forward when it was already turning round — fought where a Qurayshi chief was expected to fight, mounted and armoured in the

middle of his own clan's contingent, inside a ring of picked men of Makhzum. It was the strongest single point in the Qurayshi array and, once the wings began to spill outward, the last part of it still standing. The men who broke into that ring were not Muhajirun of the Prophet's own city-band nor famous swordsmen but two young men of the Ansar, of Medinan farming clans who had known Abu Jahl only as a name.

Mu'adh ibn 'Amr ibn al-Jamuh, of the Banu Salima, got through the guard and struck at him, and the blow took Abu Jahl's leg off at the middle of the shin. Mu'adh described it afterwards in the only terms a man of Medina had ready: the leg flew off, he said, like a date-stone spat out from under the crusher. Abu Jahl came down out of the saddle. His son 'Ikrima wheeled in on Mu'adh and cut him across the shoulder so that his arm hung by the skin at his side. Mu'adh fought on with it swinging, then — because it was in his way — put his foot on it and pulled until it tore free, and went on fighting for the rest of the day. He lived, and lived long, and it is from him that the account comes.[59] Then Mu'awwidh ibn 'Afra came over the fallen man and struck him again where he lay, and left him motionless but still breathing, and went on into the press and was killed there, deeper inside the enemy line than any other Muslim who fell that day.

On the Qurayshi left, 'Abd al-Rahman ibn 'Awf came upon Umayya ibn Khalaf of the Banu Jumah, a fat man in his own mail, with his son beside him. The two had been friends in Mecca — trading partners, on the better reports, in the years before the preaching — and Umayya asked to be taken prisoner, since a prisoner could be ransomed and a corpse could not. 'Abd al-Rahman took the two of them and started them back towards the Muslim rear.

Bilal saw them going. Umayya had owned Bilal in Mecca and had staked him out in the sun on the hot stones of the Batha to make him renounce, and what Bilal shouted, in Ibn Ishaq's wording, was: "Umayya ibn Khalaf! The

head of unbelief! I shall not live if he lives." ʿAbd al-Rahman said that they were his captives. Bilal called to the Ansar, and a knot of them closed in, and ʿAbd al-Rahman threw his own body across Umayya to keep them off and was cut for it; they killed the son first and then the father under his hands, and a stroke aimed at Umayya's leg took part of ʿAbd al-Rahman's foot as well. Ibn Ishaq has him say afterwards, without much charity: "God forgive Bilal. He has lost me my prisoners and my armour."[60]

The sources cannot get through this hour without noticing the relatives. Abu ʿUbayda ibn al-Jarrah, whom men later remembered chiefly as an administrator, killed his own father al-Jarrah in the press — a report the exegetes attached to the verse about believers who do not take their fathers' side.[61] Hamza killed Tu'ayma ibn ʿAdi, whose kin would remember it at Uhud. ʿUmar met his mother's brother, al-ʿAs ibn Hisham of Makhzum, and killed him. Abu Hudhayfa fought forward past the bodies of his father ʿUtba, his brother al-Walid and his uncle Shayba without turning aside. Abu Bakr's son ʿAbd al-Rahman, who was in the Qurayshi ranks and did not become a Muslim for years, told his father long afterwards that he had had him in his sights that day and let him pass; Abu Bakr said that he would not have done the same.[62] Hanzala, a son of Abu Sufyan, was killed somewhere in the Qurayshi centre. ʿAmir ibn al-Hadrami, who had rejected the blood-money offered to close his brother's case and get the army home, was killed on the field he had insisted on.

Then both ends of the Qurayshi line let go — the right first, the wing that had lost ʿUtba and Shayba and al-Walid before a blow was struck in the general fight, and the left within minutes of Abu Jahl going down. The standard came down. The centre was squeezed back against its own baggage at the foot of the dune, and after that it was not a battle but a climb: men throwing off mail to get up the soft slope of al-ʿAqanqal that had already cost

them the morning, horses foundering, seven hundred camels left standing where they were tethered.

As the field emptied the Prophet sent men through the fallen to find out whether Abu Jahl was among them. ʻAbdallah ibn Mas'ud found him lying in the churned sand, still alive, and set his foot on his neck. Bukhari preserves the exchange in a report from Ibn Mas'ud himself: he asked whether God had put him to shame, and Abu Jahl answered that he was nothing more than a man killed by his own people, and then asked which side had the upper hand that day. Told whose day it was, he said only: "You have climbed high, little shepherd." Ibn Ishaq adds that he asked to be struck high, at the neck, so that the head would look well when it was carried.[63] The head was carried back across the wadi and laid at the Prophet's feet, and he said that it was the Pharaoh of this community.

The Pit and the Prisoners

The pit was an old well on the floor of the wadi that had fallen in and gone dry. Nobody dug a grave for the Quraysh. In the late afternoon, with the heat coming off the sand, the men of Medina took the bodies of the chiefs by the feet and the wrists, dragged them across to the collapsed shaft, put them in, and levelled the sand over the mouth of it.[64] Ibn Ishaq names twenty-four of the dead as going into that hole, which is the figure to prefer: one fallen well will not take seventy men, and the rest were most probably covered where they lay.

The Prophet Muhammad ﷺ stood at the lip of it as the light went and spoke to them by name — "O 'Utba ibn Rabi'a, O Shayba ibn Rabi'a, O Umayya ibn Khalaf, O Abu Jahl ibn Hisham" — and asked them whether they had found what their lord promised them to be true, as he and his men had found what theirs had promised. 'Umar asked him why he was talking to bodies that could not hear. He answered that they heard him no worse than 'Umar did, but could not answer.[65]

The count, when it was made, was about seventy of the Quraysh killed and about seventy taken alive, and fourteen of the Muslims dead, six of the Muhajirun and eight of the Ansar. Seventy is a round and satisfying number and the name-lists do not quite reach it either way; but the figures are old, and consistent across reporters who disagree about almost everything else on that field.[66] The fourteen were buried on the eastern edge of the plain, near where their line had stood, and their graves are still shown there.

'Utba ibn Rabi'a was the hardest body to move. He had been a heavy man in his sixties and the party dragging him stalled in the soft sand. His son Abu Hudhayfa ibn 'Utba, who had gone over to Muhammad years before and had stood that morning in the Muslim line, watched his father hauled to the well and could not keep his face. Ibn Ishaq has the Prophet notice it and ask him whether something had entered his heart about his father, and has Abu Hudhayfa answer that he did not doubt about his father or his death, but that he had known judgement and forbearance and virtue in him and had hoped these would bring him to Islam, and that seeing what had come upon him instead grieved him. He was spoken to gently and prayed for.[67] The kinship ran into the prisoners' column too, and less gently. Mus'ab ibn 'Umayr came past his own full brother Abu 'Aziz roped in with the rest, and told the Ansari holding him to bind the man tighter, because their mother in Mecca had money and would pay.

The spoils nearly did what the Quraysh had not. A hundred and fifty camels, ten horses, and heaps of mail, helmets, swords, spears and waterskins came into the camp, and three sets of men claimed them: those who had held the line, those who had gone out over the sand after the runners, and those who had stood all day around the shelter on the rise. The argument turned bad quickly, between men who had been shoulder to shoulder an hour earlier. The opening verse of Surat al-Anfal took the question out of their hands — the spoils belonged to God and to the Messenger, and the believers were to set right the relations between them — and the Prophet had every piece brought out of every private hand into one heap, put an Ansari, 'Abdallah ibn Ka'b al-Mazini, in charge of counting it, set aside a fifth, and divided the rest into equal shares, foot and mounted, Muhajir and Ansar, with the shares of the fourteen going to their heirs.[68] The fifth — the khums, God's portion, in

practice the portion the Prophet administered for the poor and for public need — was fixed at Badr and stayed fixed.

They spent three days in the valley, because the wounded had to be fit to travel and seventy prisoners had to be roped and fed, and then went up the road north-east towards Medina. Two men did not finish the journey. At al-Safra', a valley of palms a day's march out of Badr, al-Nadr ibn al-Harith was brought out of the column and 'Ali ibn Abi Talib killed him. Al-Nadr had carried the Quraysh banner, and in Mecca he used to sit down after the Prophet had recited in the precinct of the Ka'ba and tell the Persian stories of Rustam and Isfandiyar, to show that anyone could make tales.[69] Three days later, at a place called 'Irq al-Zabya between al-Rawha' and Medina, 'Uqba ibn Abi Mu'ayt was brought out in the same way, and 'Asim ibn Thabit killed him, on Ibn Ishaq's account, which I follow.[70]

'Uqba had thrown filth on the Prophet while he prayed in Mecca and had once wound a cloak round his neck from behind and pulled. He asked why he alone of all the Quraysh, and was told, for his enmity to God and His Messenger. Ibn Ishaq gives him one more question — who would look after his sons — and one more answer: the Fire. These two were the only prisoners put to death out of about seventy; the rest watched, and walked on north.

From al-Rawha' the Prophet sent two riders ahead with the news, 'Abdallah ibn Rawaha to the upper quarters of the town and Zayd ibn Haritha to the lower, Zayd on the Prophet's own she-camel al-Qaswa' so that nobody would take him for a fugitive. Medina had been days on rumour. What the boys running out along the road wanted first was the roll of the dead, and second whether it was true that Abu Jahl was in a hole in the ground at Badr.[71]

What to do with seventy men was a harder question than what to do with the camels. Nothing in the usage of the day settled it: a raiding party

ransomed its captives or killed them as it judged, and there was no rule yet for an army that fought on God's behalf. Muslim preserves a long report on the argument, and the tradition has settled into a very tidy shape, in which the Prophet asked his two closest men and got opposite counsel. Abu Bakr said they were kinsmen and cousins, that a ransom would be a strength against the enemy, and that God might yet guide some of them. 'Umar said that they were the men who had driven the Muslims out of Mecca and called them liars, that their necks should be struck, and — in the version he is himself made to tell — that each man should be handed his own relative to kill, 'Ali given his brother 'Aqil and Hamza his brother al-'Abbas.[72] The ransom was taken.

Then Surat al-Anfal rebuked the taking of it: that no prophet should have prisoners until he had made slaughter in the land, that the believers wanted the goods of this world and God wanted the hereafter, and that had a decree not gone out already, a painful punishment would have followed. The same verses declared the money lawful to eat. 'Umar is reported to have said that he and the Prophet wept.[73]

The ransoms ran from a thousand dirhams for a poor man to 4,000 for a chief, graded by what a family could be expected to find, and Mecca sent the money north household by household, up the same road the army had come down. Some prisoners had nothing. Those of them who could read and write were told they might buy their freedom by teaching ten boys of Medina to write; when the boy could write, the teacher went home. One of those boys was Zayd ibn Thabit, who became the Prophet's scribe and, twenty years later, the man who collected the Qur'an. Suhayl ibn 'Amr, an orator whose mouth was his trade, drew from 'Umar a proposal that his lower front teeth be pulled so that he could never make a speech against the Muslims again; the Prophet refused to mutilate a man, and said that Suhayl might yet stand somewhere that would please him.[74]

Among the prisoners was the Prophet's uncle. Al-'Abbas ibn 'Abd al-Muttalib had come out with the Quraysh, was taken by Abu al-Yasar Ka'b ibn 'Amr, a small man, which was remarked on all the way to Medina, and was ransomed like anyone else — for himself, for his two nephews and for an ally — out of gold he had left behind with his wife Umm al-Fadl, which he had not mentioned until he was told about it. He asked to have the sum counted against the gold already taken from him on the field, and was told that was God's and the Muslims'. That is the plain shape of it, and the later story that he had marched under compulsion, or had been a Muslim in secret all along, will not carry the weight put on it; the family that ruled the caliphate for five centuries had every reason to want its ancestor at Badr on the right side of the wadi.[75]

Abu'l-'As ibn al-Rabi' was taken too — a merchant of 'Abd Shams, a nephew of Khadija, and husband of the Prophet's daughter Zaynab bint Muhammad, who was still in Mecca. His brother 'Amr brought the ransom, and with it a necklace of Zaynab's, onyx from Zafar, which her mother Khadija had given her on her wedding day and which she had now sent north to buy her husband. The Prophet asked his men whether they would let her have it back; they gave it up, and Abu'l-'As went home with the necklace and a private undertaking to send Zaynab to her father. He kept it. He became Muslim years afterwards and she was returned to him.

In Mecca the news came in on the third day, brought by a rider of Khuza'a, al-Haysuman ibn 'Abdallah, who came into the valley and simply began reciting the dead: 'Utba ibn Rabi'a, Shayba ibn Rabi'a, Abu Jahl ibn Hisham, Umayya ibn Khalaf, Zam'a ibn al-Aswad, Nubayh and Munabbih the sons of al-Hajjaj. Safwan ibn Umayya, sitting in the Hijr beside the Ka'ba, said that if the man still had his wits they should ask him about Safwan; they asked, and

al-Haysuman said that Safwan was sitting in the Hijr, and that he had seen his father and his brother killed. He was believed after that.[76]

Abu Lahab had not gone to Badr; he had hired al-'As ibn Hisham to go in his place against a debt, and he now sat by the Zamzam tent and waited for a witness. Abu Sufyan ibn al-Harith, the Prophet's own cousin and still then an opponent, came in from the field and was called over — come here, nephew, you have the news — and made to sit and tell it in front of the men. He told them the army had broken at the first shock, that they had been killed and taken as the Muslims pleased, and that he did not blame the Quraysh for it, because they had met men in white on piebald horses between heaven and earth, and nothing stood before them. A freedman of al-'Abbas named Abu Rafi', sitting nearby trimming arrow shafts, said gladly that those had been the angels. Abu Lahab knocked him down.

Umm al-Fadl, al-'Abbas's wife, picked up a tent-pole and opened Abu Lahab's head with it, and told him he bullied the man because his master was away. The wound went bad. Abu Lahab was dead within the week, of a pustular sickness the Meccans took for plague, and his sons would not touch the body; it was pushed into a hollow at the edge of the town and stoned over from a distance.

Al-Aswad ibn al-Muttalib had lost three sons in the wadi and had gone blind, Ibn Ishaq says, from weeping for them. Hearing a woman wailing somewhere in the town one night, he sent his slave out to learn whether the mourning had been permitted at last, so that he might weep for his own; the boy came back and said she was crying over a lost camel. In Mecca no woman was allowed to weep where she could be heard.

What Badr Broke

Abu Sufyan brought the caravan into Mecca and sold it. The goods that had come down from Gaza reached the market they were consigned to, were divided among the shareholders, and turned a profit for a city in mourning. That is the first thing to be said about Badr and the thing most easily lost: the object of the whole expedition, the reason three hundred and thirteen men had walked out of Medina in Ramadan, was obtained by the side that lost the fight. Abu Sufyan's swerve to the coast had worked. He got his cargo home along the beach road while the men who came out to protect him were buried in a dry well eighty miles to the north.[77]

The column came up to Medina over several days, driving camels it had not owned a week before and herding seventy prisoners who were, many of them, cousins of their guards. Ibn Ishaq reports that the people of the city came out along the road to meet them, the boys running as far as al-Rawha', a long day's march south, so the army was met before it was in sight of the palms. The heralds had gone ahead from al-Rawha'; Medina had had a day or two to draw the conclusion that mattered.[78]

Something on the order of seventy men of Quraysh had been killed. In a town whose adult men ran to a few thousand, that was a wound, not a mutilation. What made it a catastrophe was not the number. It was which men.

Read the Meccan dead as a list of offices rather than of persons and the shape of the disaster appears at once. 'Utba ibn Rabi'a and his brother Shayba

were the senior men of ʻAbd Shams, the clan with the largest share in the Syrian trade; ʻUtba was the man others were sent to when a quarrel needed settling. Abu Jahl was the effective head of Makhzum, which had run the boycott of the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ and his kin, and Makhzum lost a rank of its men with him, as Sahm lost Nubayh and Munabbih, the sons of al-Hajjaj. Umayya ibn Khalaf was chief of Jumah and a guarantor of Meccan credit; Zam'a ibn al-Aswad and al-Harith ibn ʻAmir stood in the same rank. Al-Nadr ibn al-Harith of ʻAbd al-Dar had carried the banner because his clan carried it by hereditary right, and the right did not survive him in any usable form.[79]

Mecca had no government. No king, no council with fixed membership, no coercive force, no treasury. What it had instead was a small number of old men whose word bound their clans and whose arrangements — the pacts of protection with the bedouin along the road, the guarantees of safe passage, the sureties for blood-money, the division of shares in a caravan — constituted the whole working order of the town. That kind of authority could not be transferred. It was personal and slow: a man acquired it over decades by judgement, wealth and patronage, and it did not pass to his heir intact. Badr killed the greater part of that generation between sunrise and noon. It did not destroy Mecca's wealth, which was in goods and credit and largely untouched, nor its capacity to raise men, demonstrated at Uhud with three thousand of them. It destroyed Meccan seniority, which is why a fight of some 950 men against three hundred and thirteen mattered out of all proportion to its size.

W. Montgomery Watt read the conflict between Mecca and Medina as an economic one, a struggle over the northern road and the trade that moved along it, and about the road he was substantially right: Mecca's route to Syria ran past a hostile town which could now close it at will. But a road is not only a road. The men who died at Badr were the men who had negotiated the

passage of that road, tribe by tribe, over thirty years, and their deaths cost Mecca its arrangements as much as its access.[80]

Abu Sufyan ibn Harb inherited the leadership of Quraysh by survival. He had not been in the first rank before Badr — he was a caravan master of good family who happened, on 17 Ramadan, to be a hundred miles away with the goods — and he came out of it the senior surviving man of ʻAbd Shams and head of the war party, alongside Safwan ibn Umayya, whose father had died at the wells. Both men's standing rested on a killing that had to be answered. That is the mechanism by which Mecca's reply became necessarily a war of revenge rather than a calculation about the road: those who now spoke for the city had fathers, brothers and sons in the pit at Badr. The bereaved of Badr paid for and filled the ranks at Uhud, which follows from the pit as an answer follows a question.[81]

Inside Medina the change was quieter and more thorough. The Muhajirun, who had arrived with nothing and had been living on other men's dates, had gone out and won, and their standing in the town was never afterwards that of dependents. The Ansar, who had undertaken to defend a man and had at Dhafiran committed themselves to attacking his enemies, were past the point where the commitment could be revisited: they had killed the chiefs of Quraysh, they had eight dead of their own, and no arrangement was open to them that did not involve Muhammad's survival. The uncommitted found their position narrowed accordingly, and so did the Jewish tribes of the oasis, whose treaties had been made with a refugee community and now bound them to a victorious one. The Banu Qaynuqa' were expelled in Shawwal of the same year, and that belongs to another chapter.[82]

Surat al-Anfal, the chapter of the Qur'an that tradition attaches to Badr, is not an account of the battle. Read straight through, it is a document of the aftermath: it opens on the quarrel over the spoils, legislates the fifth — the

khums, which the jurists date to this day and which is the first piece of public finance in Islam — rebukes the taking of ransom for the prisoners, and looks back at the day in images rather than narrative: the sleep, the rain, the thousand angels, the handful of dust. What comes nearest to describing the encounter is the verse reminding the believers that they had wanted the other of the two parties, the unarmed one. And it gives the day a name: the day of the furqan, of distinction, the day the two ways were told apart, and by that name the tradition afterwards knew it.[83]

It also produced a rank. To have been at Badr was a status a man carried for life: he was a badri, one of the people of Badr, and in a community rapidly becoming a state this was the nearest thing to a patent of nobility. ʻUmar as caliph paid the badriyyun the highest stipends, and faults were forgiven them that were forgiven to no one else. Lists were kept, and they are why we can name so large a proportion of three hundred and thirteen men — and also why the names need watching, since a rank worth having is a rank worth claiming, and families had a century in which to claim it.[84]

That caution applies more widely, and is worth stating plainly once. The sources for Badr are good by the standards of seventh-century Arabia and thin by any other: the Qur'anic material is contemporary but allusive, and the narrative accounts were written down a century and more after the event by men who were pious, partisan and dependent on family tradition. Hold the shape of the day with some confidence and the details with less. The numbers are round and convenient. The speeches are reconstructions in the idiom of the reporter, however faithful to the sense. The order of the fighting — who struck whom, and when — is the part of any battle account that survives worst, and at Badr it has been sorted into a series of duels by men writing for audiences who liked duels. What can be trusted is what nobody had an interest in inventing.[85]

That is where the contingency comes back. A tradition free to shape its foundation story would not have had the believers hoping for the unarmed caravan, or Abu Sufyan getting clean away, or the Meccan column turning for home before a blood-debt shamed it forward, or two clans withdrawing, or the whole collision hanging on there being one reliable water in that stretch of the Hijaz in March. Those details survive because they were remembered. The Prophet lived eight more years; Mecca opened its gates to him six years after Badr, and Abu Sufyan was among the men who came out to arrange the surrender. The fourteen graves on the floor of the wadi are still shown. Everything that followed in Arabia followed from a fight that began because two water-parties met at a well in the dark.

A Note on the Sources

No one who fought at Badr wrote an account of it. The battle was fought on a Friday morning in March 624 by some thirteen hundred men in a dry valley five days' march from Medina, and the earliest continuous narrative of it that survives was composed by a man who died roughly a hundred and forty years later. Between the event and the book stand four or five generations of speech, and almost everything a reader should know about these sources follows from that.

What we have comes in four layers of unequal weight. **The Qur'an** is the earliest by a long way, and the only material contemporary with the men who were there. Surat al-Anfal — "the Spoils" — is a chapter of some seventy-five verses which the tradition places at Badr and just after it. But it is not a chronicle. It never names Badr's day, its commanders, its dead, or its numbers. It speaks of "the day of the two parties," of the lower ground and the further ground, of a caravan the believers had wanted and a fight they had not; it rebukes them for quarrelling over the spoils, calls the sleep that fell on them a security from God, and speaks of a thousand angels sent down. It is addressed to men who needed no scene set, which makes it enormously valuable and almost useless for narrative — no hour, no name, no line of speech.

The maghazi and the sira are where the story comes from. *Maghazi* means the raids: campaign literature. Its foundation is Muhammad ibn Ishaq (d. 150/767), whose life of the Prophet survives not in his own words but in the recension of Ibn Hisham (d. 218/833). Then al-Waqidi (d. 207/822),

whose *Kitab al-Maghazi* treats the expeditions alone and in far greater detail; Ibn Sa'd (d. 230/845), al-Waqidi's secretary, whose *Tabaqat* preserves the *badri* lists, the roll of men who were at Badr and the most prized entry a Muslim family could claim; and al-Tabari (d. 310/923), precious for setting rival reports side by side instead of choosing between them. The distance is the problem. Ibn Ishaq wrote in early Abbasid Iraq about a battle fought by the ancestors of men then disputing who should rule, and tribes had claims to press: which clan's man struck down Abu Jahl stayed a question of family honour for centuries, and the sources give three answers, each traceable to an interested house. The reigning dynasty had an ancestor on the wrong side of the field, and reports about al-'Abbas soften with time.

The hadith collections were not written as history. Bukhari (d. 256/870) and Muslim (d. 261/875) pick up Badr incidentally, wherever a legal point needed a precedent — in the books on campaigns, on the fifth share of plunder, on funerals. But theirs is the most rigorously filtered material we have, because the hadith scholars developed the *isnad*: the chain of transmitters, each named, running back to an eyewitness, with the reliability of every link investigated and recorded. It did real work, and it has a limit its own builders stated. An isnad certifies that a man of good memory said he heard this from another such man; it cannot certify that the first speaker remembered accurately, and it constrains invention rather than the drift of a true story towards a better one.

The poetry was the Arab medium of record, composed at the time and held in place by its metre, which makes it in principle the earliest narrative layer of all — and the least reliable in detail, because its business was to magnify one clan and diminish another, and later partisans forged it freely. Verse is used here for atmosphere and names, not for facts.

The two who matter

Ibn Ishaq and al-Waqidi carry this chapter, and they fail in different directions.

Ibn Ishaq has shape. He tells Badr as a sequence with a logic to it: a caravan, a warning, two musters, a march, a valley, wells, a night of rain, a morning. He names his informants often, and often they are descendants of participants — the account of Abu Jahl's severed leg comes down in the family of the man who cut it off. He was also criticised in his own lifetime. Malik ibn Anas, the great jurist of Medina, is reported to have called him a liar; Ahmad ibn Hanbal thought him acceptable for campaign narrative but would not build law on him. The charges were that he took material from Jewish and Christian informants, that he recited poetry of doubtful authenticity, and — most substantially — that he was loose with his chains, writing "some of the people of knowledge told me" where a hadith scholar wanted four names. The looseness is real: he is good on the frame and shakier inside it. Ibn Hisham then states in his preface what he left out: matter with no bearing on the Prophet, poems no authority recognised, things "which it would be offensive to discuss," and things that would distress people. That is a candid editor with a policy, and we cannot see through him.

Al-Waqidi is the opposite case and the more seductive one. He knows the name of the hillock, the hour of the day, the words a man said to his brother, the camels slaughtered at each halt, the coats of mail in each army; his topography is precise enough that modern surveys have been able to test it against the terrain. That richness is why he must be handled with tongs, because detail of such specificity does not survive two centuries of oral transmission: it is either recovered from local knowledge or it is the filling-in a good storyteller does with thin materials.

The tendency of the whole literature runs one way, towards harmony and towards wonder. Contradictions get reconciled by later compilers, bare reports acquire circumstance, and divine help acquires numbers, then names, then faces. The angels are the clearest case: the Qur'an says a thousand and describes no fighting; Ibn Ishaq adds a voice and a named horse; al-Waqidi adds positions in the line; in the later popular literature they have biographies and wear yellow turbans to match al-Zubayr's. That sequence tells us much about the material and little about Badr.

How much of it is true

The sceptical position holds that the campaign narratives are largely secondary — that they grew out of the Qur'an rather than alongside it. Later Muslims, on this reading, found allusive verses about a day of two parties, a caravan and a thousand angels, and built the circumstances those allusions required, furnishing the result with names out of tribal memory. In its strongest form it notes that the sira's Badr material maps onto Surat al-Anfal almost verse by verse, which is what one would expect if the story had been made to explain the verses. It cannot be waved away.

The moderate position, where most working historians now sit — Montgomery Watt in *Muhammad at Medina* is its most careful practitioner on Badr, and Fred Donner has argued the general case — concedes much of that about the texture while insisting on a hard core. Names, places, outcomes and rough dates behave differently from dialogue and detail, being the things a community organises itself around. The *badri* lists are the test case: to have been at Badr conferred status, a stipend and precedence for generations, and a tradition inventing freely could not have held a roll of three hundred names against three centuries of scrutiny by rival families.

Badr sits about as well in that framework as any event of its period can. That a battle was fought at its wells in Ramadan of the second year after the hijra, following a failed interception of a Meccan caravan out of Syria; that the Muslims were outnumbered and won; that ʻUtba ibn Rabiʼa, Abu Jahl and Umayya ibn Khalaf died there; that prisoners were ransomed and the spoils caused a quarrel settled by revelation — these are as secure as anything known about seventh-century Arabia. The hour-by-hour texture is not, and neither is the dialogue; and the chapter's most vivid moments are dialogue.

What this chapter did, and where to doubt it

Three rules govern what follows. The chapter commits in the prose and argues in the notes, so that a reader who skips every note meets an unbroken story while one who reads them finds the disputes set out. It prefers the report that costs somebody something — the version leaving a commander doubted, an army indisciplined, a Companion behaving badly — because tidiness in this literature is usually a sign of handling. And it reports the religious material as report: the dream of ʻAtika bint ʻAbd al-Muttalib, the sleep before the battle, the angels, the handful of dust are given as the sources give them, with the attribution visible. To debunk them would substitute the historian's metaphysics for the sources'; to assert them, the sources' for the reader's.

Four passages a careful reader should hold loosely. **The dream of ʻAtika**, in which a rider cries in the valley of Mecca that the treacherous people should go out to their deaths in three days, and the messenger from the caravan arrives on the third: it comes through Hashimite channels, its ending fits its beginning too neatly, and its punchline is al-ʻAbbas — ancestor of the Abbasid caliphs — scoring off Abu Jahl in public. **The speeches at Dhafiran**: something was certainly said at that halt, but the clause about following the Prophet into the sea is attached to three speakers in three sources, the

signature of a formula rather than a memory. **Sawad ibn Ghaziyya and the arrow-shaft**: the shaft used to straighten the line is secure, the bared belly is of a recognisable didactic type and appears first in al-Waqidi. **The single combats**: champions certainly fought between the lines, but the reported speech comes from a moment when few stood close enough to hear it.

To which add the whole middle of the battle. Thirteen hundred men and a hundred horses churning a dry valley floor raise a dust-cloud inside which no one sees past the men alongside him, and any account that gives that melee a shape is giving it one it did not have. The chapter tells the hour as a series of episodes because that is the form in which the evidence reaches us, not because that is how it felt.

What the Sources Disagree About

The chapter commits in its main text to one reading of each disputed point and marks the commitment lightly, so that the narrative keeps moving. This appendix pays the debt. Four tests are applied throughout: how early the report is, whether it is consistent with the rest of the account, whether it is physically possible on the ground at Badr in March, and whose interests it serves. The last is the sharpest and most easily abused, and is used only where the interest is plain.

*

1. The size of the Qurayshi army. Ibn Ishaq, through Ibn Hisham, gives "between nine hundred and a thousand"; others round to a flat thousand; al-Waqidi allows a thousand or more; some later writers put thirteen hundred out of Mecca, which need not contradict, since Banu Zuhra turned back at al-Juhfa and took somewhere between a hundred and three hundred men home. (Banu 'Adi ibn Ka'b, sometimes bracketed with them, never marched at all.) The most interesting figure is not a figure but a calculation. Two captured water-carriers said nine or ten camels were slaughtered daily at the halts, and the Prophet reckoned a hundred men to a camel. That the tradition preserves the method and not only the answer counts in its favour; fabricators supply totals. Nine hundred and fifty is a good ancient estimate, not a muster roll.

2. The number of Qurayshi horses. The maghazi writers agree on a hundred, with the richest men mounted and barded. A minority report allows Quraysh only two — the same number the Muslims had — which is almost certainly either a copyist's eye slipping between the two inventories or a homiletic flattening meant to make the victory turn wholly on faith. Two things favour the hundred. No source describes a Qurayshi cavalry charge, which is exactly what an inflator would have supplied: the horses appear on the approach, in the flight, and nowhere between. And the ground explains their uselessness, soft rain-wetted sand being no place for cavalry. A hundred idle horses is a stranger and better-evidenced fact than two.

3. The size and value of the caravan. A thousand camels, goods worth some fifty thousand dinars, thirty or forty men escorting. Some reports halve the camels to seven hundred; the escort is occasionally raised to seventy. Fifty thousand arrives already rounded and means "the whole Meccan trading capital of that season" — Ibn Hisham's own point when he says hardly a man or woman of Quraysh with ten dinars had stayed out of it. The thousand camels are more defensible, explaining the scale of the alarm. The small escort is the strongest detail of the three, the least flattering to Quraysh and the one that makes the campaign intelligible.

4. Whether the Muslims marched out for battle or for plunder. The maghazi literature, written when Badr had become the archetype of holy war, tends to present an army going out to meet an army. The Qur'an, earlier by a century, says something harder: that God promised the believers one of two parties, and they wanted the other one, the unarmed one (Q 8:5-8). The verse is unflattering, which is why it must be early; no later apologist invents a rebuke that has the companions setting out after baggage camels and vexed to find a war instead. The narrative sources corroborate it — three hundred men

with two horses and six coats of mail, and a consultation at Dhafiran necessary only because the object had changed. The chapter follows the Qur'an.

5. Who killed Abu Jahl. Four names circulate, and the reports compete for credit rather than contradict. Ibn Ishaq has Mu'adh ibn 'Amr ibn al-Jamuh break the ring of guards and take Abu Jahl's leg off at the shin — Mu'adh's own image was of a date-stone spat from under a crusher — and then Mu'awwidh ibn 'Afra beat the fallen man and pass on into the press, where he was killed. Bukhari preserves a report in which Ibn Mas'ud finds Abu Jahl among the wounded, still breathing, sets a foot on his neck and takes his head. Variants substitute Mu'adh ibn 'Afra for Mu'adh ibn 'Amr; later accounts credit the whole to Ibn Mas'ud, or to 'Ali. The adopted sequence reconciles the substantial reports and explains why each survived: three men could claim a hand in it.

6. Who killed 'Uqba ibn Abi Mu'ayt, and where. Not on the field. 'Uqba was taken alive and executed on the march home, at 'Irq al-Zabya between al-Rawha' and Medina. Ibn Ishaq names 'Asim ibn Thabit al-Ansari; a rival report gives the killing to 'Ali ibn Abi Talib, who had certainly carried out the other roadside execution, that of al-Nadr ibn al-Harith at al-Safra'. The 'Ali version looks like assimilation — two executions on one road within days, one securely attributed, the second drawn after it. 'Asim is preferred and the killings kept distinct. Both traditions preserve 'Uqba's protest that he alone of Quraysh had been singled out.

7. Who killed Umayya ibn Khalaf, and Bilal's part. The core is told by 'Abd al-Rahman ibn 'Awf himself, and its survival in that form is the best argument for it, since it does its narrator no credit. He had taken Umayya — a guest-friend from Mecca — and Umayya's son prisoner, and was leading them to the rear when Bilal ibn Rabah, whom Umayya had owned and tortured, cried out that the head of unbelief should not live while he lived. Ansar came

at the shout and cut both men down in their captor's hands, and 'Abd al-Rahman lost the ransom and said so. Variants make Bilal himself the killer, which is tidier and therefore more suspect. A prisoner-taker robbed of his prize and grumbling about it is not what traditions invent.

8. Whether al-'Abbas fought willingly. The Prophet's uncle was taken prisoner by Abu al-Yasar Ka'b ibn 'Amr, a small man against a very large one, and a persistent tradition holds that he had come out under compulsion, was secretly a Muslim, and had informed for the Muslims in Mecca. It matters because the 'Abbasid caliphs, under whose patronage much of this literature was compiled, descended from him. Against the exculpation stand details preserved even by writers sympathetic to him: that he took his day in the rotation of camel-slaughtering that fed the marching army, which no man dragged along would do; that the water-carriers named him among the great men of the column; and the Prophet's answer to his plea, that outwardly he had been against them and must ransom himself and his kin. He fought; the compulsion story is later and interested.

9. The count of the dead and the prisoners. Seventy killed and seventy taken is Ibn Ishaq's figure and is repeated everywhere; the chapter uses it and admits at once that seventy is the kind of number traditions like. The name-lists tell against exactness: Ibn Ishaq's own roll of the Qurayshi dead runs to fewer than seventy, and al-Waqidi's differs from it both ways. The twenty-four chiefs thrown into the well-pit are counted with more confidence, the great men being known by name where their slaves were not. Where a formula and a name-list conflict, the list is earlier material. The Muslim figure runs the other way — fourteen dead, six Muhajirun and eight Ansar, individually commemorated; a rival count of twenty-two looks like the fourteen plus men who later died of wounds.

10. The bearer of the second black banner. Three standards are agreed: the white liwa' of the army carried by Mus'ab ibn 'Umayr, whose clan held the hereditary right to it; the black rayah called al-'Uqab, the Eagle, carried by 'Ali ibn Abi Talib; and a second black banner for the Ansar. The last is disputed between Sa'd ibn Mu'adh, chief of the Aws, and al-Hubab ibn al-Mundhir of the Khazraj. The day's logic favours al-Hubab: Sa'd spent the battle at the shelter as head of the Prophet's guard and cannot have carried a banner in the line, and the Khazraj were much the larger of the two Medinan confederations present. Some accounts give Aws and Khazraj a banner each, making four — unresolvable, and the chapter follows al-Hubab without labouring it.

11. The date and the day. The great majority of reports give 17 Ramadan of the year 2; a minority prefers 19 or 21, and the variance is explained by disagreement over whether the month began on the crescent seen at Mecca or at Medina — a day either way, propagating through every later reckoning. The conversion to 13 March 624 rests on retrojecting the lunar calendar from the era of the Hijra; it is arithmetic, not observation, and is sound to within a day or two and no better. The tradition that it was a Friday is early and bound up with the naming of the day as the yawm al-furqan; the calculation does not support it, since tabular 13 March 624 was a Tuesday, and the two or three days of drift needed to reconcile them are exactly what an observational calendar produces over two years. Read "about the middle of March" behind the date, and prefer the Friday to the arithmetic.

12. The angels: a thousand, three thousand, or five thousand. Three Qur'anic passages give three figures, and the older commentators were alive to the problem. Surat al-Anfal has God answer the believers' cry with a thousand angels, rank on rank (Q 8:9). Al 'Imran, which most commentators also referred to Badr, has three thousand sent down (Q 3:124) and then, conditionally, five thousand if they held steady (Q 3:125). The classical

resolution is sequential: a thousand promised, three thousand sent, five thousand contingent on conduct. An alternative reading, also old, refers the Al ʿImran verses to Uhud, where the condition was conspicuously not met. What is not in doubt is the direction of growth. Ibn Ishaq and al-Waqidi supply named angels, Jibril in a yellow turban, men hearing a whip crack overhead; the Qur'anic layer is allusive and names nobody.

13. Whether the duels happened as described. The single combats — mubaraza — are among the best-attested episodes of the day and the most formally shaped. Ibn Ishaq has three young Ansar step out first, ʿAwf and Mu'awwidh the sons of ʿAfra with ʿAbdallah ibn Rawaha, and be sent back; the Prophet then called for men of Quraysh's own kin, and ʿUbayda ibn al-Harith, Hamza and ʿAli went out against ʿUtba ibn Rabi'a, Shayba ibn Rabi'a and al-Walid ibn ʿUtba. Some accounts omit the Ansar altogether. Their rejection is preferred because it is unflattering to the Ansar, whose descendants were telling this story in Medina a century later, and because it supplies a motive the shorter versions lose: the challengers had demanded equals of their own blood. The shape is suspiciously neat; the substance stands.

14. Abu al-Bakhtari and the exemption order. Certain men of Quraysh were named as not to be killed if they could be taken — men who had defended the Prophet in Mecca or refused to join the boycott of Banu Hashim — and Abu al-Bakhtari ibn Hisham was among them. Ibn Ishaq has al-Mujadhdhir ibn Dhiyad al-Balawi find him, tell him he was exempt, and be asked about his companion, for whom al-Mujadhdhir had no order. Abu al-Bakhtari would not be spared alone: the women of Mecca should never say he had abandoned his friend to save himself. He was killed. The lists generally include him, though at least one confuses him with his kinsman al-ʿAs ibn

Hisham. The exemption order is sometimes doubted as retrospective softening, but nobody gained by inventing an order a Qurayshi refused.

15. The ransoms and the literate prisoners. The reported range runs from a thousand dirhams for a poor man to four thousand for a chief, with some sources naming four hundred for the poorest. Scaling ransom to standing is plausible in itself — blood-money worked the same way — but the round thousands are bands, not receipts. Two exceptions are well attested: Abu ʿAzza al-Jumahi, a penniless poet with five daughters, released on a promise never to lampoon the Muslims again; and al-Muttalib ibn Hantab, let go because nobody of his people was there to pay. The report that literate captives ransomed themselves by teaching Medinan children to write — ten children each, in the commonest version — has no isnad strong enough to settle it, and ten is the sort of number that gets supplied. Something of the kind is credible in a town where writing was scarce.

16. Why Quraysh kept marching after the caravan was safe. Ibn Ishaq's account turns on the caravan: the alarm, the muster, Abu Sufyan's word that the danger was past, and a column that had begun to turn round when Abu Jahl shamed it forward. Al-Waqidi's fuller council makes the second motive explicit, that the road itself was at stake and a Medina able to threaten the Syrian traffic would have to be broken. These are not alternatives, and the chapter takes them in sequence. What settles the shape is ʿAmir ibn al-Hadrami rising with his shirt torn to demand vengeance for his brother, killed at Nakhla: a blood-claim publicly raised could not be set aside without dishonour. That is how a rescue no longer needed became a war, and it is too awkward to be invention.

17. The rain and the sleep. Surat al-Anfal speaks of a slumber sent as security and of water sent down to firm the believers' feet (Q 8:11). The narrative sources supply the squall: rain in the small hours, firming the gravel

on the Muslim bank and turning the soft sand where Quraysh were descending al-ʻAqanqal into heavy going. Whether the verse describes the weather or the weather was inferred from the verse is answered by the ground: the contrast between the banks is a real feature of the place, and the accounts of the Qurayshi descent — slow, loud, disordered, the horses labouring — read as observation rather than exegesis.

18. al-Hubab, the wells, and whether they were stopped. Ibn Ishaq has al-Hubab ibn al-Mundhir ask whether the halting-place was revelation or judgement, and on being told judgement, advise moving up to the nearest well on the Qurayshi side, taking it, and building a cistern. Some read the episode as a doublet, the same decision told once as the Prophet's and once as a companion's. The substance is unimpeachable: the Muslims ended the night holding the water and Quraysh did not. Whether the further wells were filled in or merely denied is not recoverable, and matters little — an army that cannot reach a well is as thirsty as one whose well is choked.

✳

The pattern of these disagreements is more instructive than any one of them. The tradition is firm about ground, order and sequence: where the wells were, which bank each army held, that the rain fell, that the duels came before the general engagement, that fourteen Muslims died and their names were these. It drifts in three places only. Round numbers grow and tidy themselves. Credit multiplies, as the descendants of the men involved acquire reasons to care. And the supernatural material, spare and allusive in the Qur'an, becomes elaborate and named in writers working a century later. The drift is not random, and it is not evidence that the whole is fiction: it is what happens to remembered fact passing through generations of men with claims

to press — tribal, dynastic, doctrinal — who could press them only in the gaps of a story already too well known to alter. Abu Jahl acquires killers; nobody acquires a victory Quraysh did not lose. The most useful habit here is to ask of any detail whether it flatters its transmitter. Much of what survives from Badr does not, and that is the strongest argument these sources make on their own behalf.

The Principal Figures

The Muslims

The Prophet Muhammad ﷺ — Banu Hashim of Quraysh. Commanded in person, chose the ground on the near bank, dressed the ranks with an arrow-shaft, and prayed in the ʿarish with Abu Bakr beside him. Forbade the killing of al-ʿAbbas and of the Hashimites who had been dragged out unwilling. Died at Medina in Rabiʾ I 11 AH / June 632, eight years after Badr.

Abu Bakr al-Siddiq (ʿAbd Allah ibn Abi Quhafa) — Banu Taym. Muhajir. Sat with the Prophet in the shelter and put the fallen cloak back on his shoulders; at the council on the prisoners he argued for ransom. His own son ʿAbd al-Rahman stood in the Quraysh line and did not convert until later. First caliph; died 13 AH / 634.

ʿUmar ibn al-Khattab — Banu ʿAdi. Muhajir, in the ranks. Killed his own maternal uncle al-ʿAs ibn Hisham ibn al-Mughira. Argued for striking off the prisoners' heads and lost the argument. Second caliph; assassinated at Medina, 23 AH / 644.

ʿAli ibn Abi Talib — Banu Hashim. Muhajir, about twenty-three, one of the three who answered the challenge to single combat and the only one to walk away from it; killed al-Walid ibn ʿUtba, then Nawfal ibn Khuwaylid and others. Carried the Prophet's black banner, al-ʿUqab, by most reports. Fourth caliph; assassinated at Kufa, 40 AH / 661.

Hamza ibn ʿAbd al-Muttalib — Banu Hashim. The Prophet's uncle, and the most conspicuous man on the field: he wore an ostrich feather in his helmet so that he could be picked out. Killed Shayba ibn Rabi'a in the duel, al-Aswad ibn ʿAbd al-Asad before it, and Tu'ayma ibn ʿAdi after. Killed at Uhud, 3 AH / 625.

ʿUbayda ibn al-Harith — Banu al-Muttalib. Muhajir, the oldest of the three champions; the reports make him something over sixty, and a kinsman of the Prophet's, which is why ʿUtba accepted him as a match — the pairing was by age and standing rather than by strength. Fought ʿUtba ibn Rabi'a, wounded him mortally, and lost his own leg to the same exchange; carried off the field on a cloak. Died of the wound at al-Safra' on the march home, the last of the fourteen to die and the only one who did not die in the valley.

al-Zubayr ibn al-ʿAwwam — Banu Asad ibn ʿAbd al-ʿUzza. Muhajir; one of only two mounted men in the army, recognisable by a yellow turban. Ran his spear through the eye-slit of ʿUbayda ibn Sa'id ibn al-ʿAs's visor, the one gap in a suit of armour that covered everything else. Killed in 36 AH / 656 after the Battle of the Camel.

Mus'ab ibn ʿUmayr — Banu ʿAbd al-Dar. Muhajir; carried the white liwa'. Took his own full brother Abu ʿAziz prisoner and told the man holding him to tie the ropes tighter, because their mother in Mecca was rich and would pay. Killed at Uhud carrying the same standard.

ʿAbd al-Rahman ibn ʿAwf — Banu Zuhra. Muhajir, in the ranks. Tried to bring Umayya ibn Khalaf and his son out of the melee alive, on the strength of an old friendship, and watched the Ansar kill them both in front of him. Became the wealthiest of the Companions; died 32 AH / 652.

Sa'd ibn Abi Waqqas — Banu Zuhra. Muhajir; an archer, and one of the younger men in the ranks — the reports of his age at conversion put him in his

late twenties at Badr. His younger brother ʿUmayr was among the dead. Later conquered Iraq and founded Kufa; died at Medina about 55 AH / 675, one of the last survivors of Badr.

Abu ʿUbayda ibn al-Jarrah — Banu al-Harith ibn Fihr. Muhajir, in mail in the centre. His father al-Jarrah was in the opposing line; the reports say he avoided him as long as he could and then killed him. Commanded in Syria; died in the plague of ʿAmwas, 18 AH / 639.

Abu Hudhayfa ibn ʿUtba — Banu ʿAbd Shams. Muhajir. His father ʿUtba, his uncle Shayba and his brother al-Walid were all killed at Badr, all three in the opening duel; he was seen weeping as their bodies were dragged to the pit and the Prophet spoke to him gently. Killed at al-Yamama, 12 AH / 633.

ʿAbdallah ibn Mas'ud — of Hudhayl, a client of Banu Zuhra. Muhajir; a small, slight man. Scouted the Quraysh camp with ʿAmmar ibn Yasir on the night before. Found Abu Jahl down but not dead, finished him and cut off his head. Later the great Qur'an teacher of Kufa; died 32 AH / 653.

al-Miqdad ibn ʿAmr al-Aswad — of Bahra', confederate of Banu Zuhra. Muhajir; the second of the two horsemen. Had spoken for the march at the council in Medina. Died 33 AH / 653. One minority report makes him, not ʿAli, the executioner of al-Nadr ibn al-Harith.†

Bilal ibn Rabah — Abyssinian, freedman of Abu Bakr. Muhajir. Recognised Umayya ibn Khalaf, who had owned and tortured him in Mecca, being led away as a prisoner, and shouted until the Ansar cut him down. The Prophet's mu'adhdhin; died at Damascus about 20 AH / 641.

ʿAmmar ibn Yasir — client of Banu Makhzum. Muhajir; sent with Ibn Mas'ud to look over the Quraysh camp in the dark. Killed at Siffin, 37 AH / 657, fighting for ʿAli.

Zayd ibn Haritha — freedman and adopted son of the Prophet. Muhajir. Rode ahead from al-Rawha' on the Prophet's own she-camel al-Qaswa' to carry the news of the victory into Medina. Commanded at Mu'ta and was killed there, 8 AH / 629.

'Ukkasha ibn Mihsan — Banu Asad ibn Khuzayma, an ally. Muhajir; fought on with a wooden staff after his sword broke, which is the detail that best conveys how few weapons the army had. Killed in the Ridda wars at Buzakha by Tulayha ibn Khuwaylid, 12 AH / 633.

Sa'd ibn Mu'adh — Aws, Banu 'Abd al-Ashhal; chief of his clan. Spoke for the Ansar at the council before the march — "if you took us into the sea we would plunge in with you" — and proposed and commanded the guard on the 'arish. Took an arrow at the siege of the Trench in 5 AH and died of the wound.

al-Hubab ibn al-Mundhir — Khazraj, Banu Salima. Asked the Prophet whether the first halting-place was revelation or his own judgement, and on being told it was judgement, urged pushing on to the nearest well of Badr and wrecking the others. The advice gave the Muslims the water. Died in 'Umar's caliphate.

Mu'adh ibn 'Amr ibn al-Jamuh — Khazraj, Banu Salima. Cut Abu Jahl's leg from under him — the wound that put him on the ground. 'Ikrima ibn Abi Jahl nearly took his arm off in return; he fought on with it hanging and finally tore it away and threw it aside. Lived into 'Uthman's reign.

'Awf ibn al-Harith ibn 'Afra — Khazraj, Banu al-Najjar. Asked the Prophet what makes God laugh with delight at a servant, was told, a man plunging into the enemy without mail, and stripped off his coat and did it. Killed at Badr, most reports say by Abu Jahl.

Mu'awwidh ibn al-Harith ibn 'Afra — Khazraj, Banu al-Najjar. Brother of 'Awf. Struck at Abu Jahl where he lay and was himself killed soon after.

The two brothers are the reason the sources speak of the sons of ʿAfra in the same breath as Abu Jahl's death.

Abu Dujana Simak ibn Kharasha — Khazraj, Banu Sa'ida. In the line at Badr; the red headband and the Prophet's sword belong to Uhud, not here. Killed at al-Yamama, 12 AH / 633, by most reports.

ʿAbdallah ibn Rawaha — Khazraj, Banu al-Harith. In the ranks; sent with Zayd as the second herald of the victory. At the council on the prisoners he sided with ʿUmar for execution. Killed at Mu'ta, 8 AH / 629.

al-Mujadhdhir ibn Dhiyad al-Balawi — of Balī, confederate of the Aws. Killed Abu al-Bakhtari against his own wish, after offering him quarter twice. Killed at Uhud by al-Harith ibn Suwayd, in payment for a pre-Islamic blood debt.

Khubayb ibn Isaf — Khazraj, Banu al-Harith. Killed al-Harith ibn ʿAmir ibn Nawfal. He had come out to join the march while still a pagan and was sent back until he accepted Islam.

Abu al-Yasar Kaʿb ibn ʿAmr — Khazraj, Banu Salima. A short man, and the captor of al-ʿAbbas, which was thought remarkable enough that the sources argue about how he managed it. Also killed Munabbih ibn al-Hajjaj. Died about 55 AH.

ʿAsim ibn Thabit — Aws, Banu ʿAmr ibn ʿAwf. An archer in the Aws line, and by the better-attested account the man who put ʿUqba ibn Abi Mu'ayt to death at ʿIrq al-Zabya on the road home.† Killed at al-Raji', 4 AH.

Abu Lubaba ibn ʿAbd al-Mundhir — Aws, Banu ʿAmr ibn ʿAwf. Turned back at al-Rawha' to hold Medina, and was counted among the men of Badr in the division of the spoils although he never saw the field. His brother Mubashshir was killed there.

The Quraysh

Abu Jahl (ʿAmr ibn Hisham) — Banu Makhzum. Not the nominal commander but the effective one, since he broke every attempt to call the campaign off; held the centre with his own clan, the largest contingent on the field. Lost a leg to Muʾadh ibn ʿAmr, was struck by Muʾawwidh ibn ʿAfra, and was finished on the ground by ʿAbdallah ibn Masʾud, who took his head.† Thrown into the qalib.

ʿUtba ibn Rabiʾa — Banu ʿAbd Shams. The senior man of Quraysh present and the one who did not want the battle: he rode the front on his red camel urging withdrawal and offered to pay the blood-money for ʿAmr al-Hadrami out of his own purse. Taunted as a coward by Abu Jahl, he walked out to the duel, could find no helmet large enough for his head, and bound a cloth round it instead. Mortally wounded by ʿUbayda ibn al-Harith. Thrown into the qalib.

Shayba ibn Rabiʾa — Banu ʿAbd Shams. Brother of ʿUtba; the second of the three champions. Killed by Hamza. Thrown into the qalib.

al-Walid ibn ʿUtba — Banu ʿAbd Shams. Son of ʿUtba, the youngest of the three champions, killed by ʿAli in the first moments of the combat. His brother Abu Hudhayfa was in the Muslim line. Thrown into the qalib.

Umayya ibn Khalaf — Banu Jumah. A rich and reluctant man who had to be shamed into marching, and Bilal's former owner. Taken alive under ʿAbd al-Rahman ibn ʿAwf's protection and killed anyway, with his son ʿAli ibn Umayya, when Bilal recognised him. Thrown into the qalib.

Abu Sufyan ibn Harb — Banu ʿAbd Shams. Master of the caravan, and the reason for everything that followed: he sent Damdam ibn ʿAmr to Mecca for help, then swung the column west to the coast road and brought it home untouched — and so was not at the battle at all. His son Hanzala was killed there and another son, ʿAmr, taken prisoner. Later became a Muslim at the conquest of Mecca; died about 32 AH / 653.

al-ʿAbbas ibn ʿAbd al-Muttalib — Banu Hashim. The Prophet's uncle, in the Quraysh ranks. Taken prisoner by Abu al-Yasar and bound so tightly that his groaning kept the Prophet from sleeping until the ropes were eased. Assessed the heaviest ransom of the day: for himself, his two nephews and his ally. Whether he came out under compulsion or willingly is the single most argued question in the roster.† Later a Muslim; died about 32 AH.

ʿAqil ibn Abi Talib — Banu Hashim. Brother of ʿAli, forced out with the army; taken prisoner and ransomed by al-ʿAbbas. Later a Muslim.

Talib ibn Abi Talib — Banu Hashim. Eldest brother of ʿAli, dragged out with the Quraysh. He was neither among the dead nor among the prisoners, and nothing further is known of him — a gap the sources do not fill.

ʿUqba ibn Abi Muʾayt — Banu ʿAbd Shams. Among the loudest for battle; in Mecca he had been the man who threw filth at the Prophet and once tried to strangle him at prayer. Taken alive and put to death on the return march at ʿIrq al-Zabya, by ʿAsim ibn Thabit in the better-attested version, by ʿAli in others.†

al-Nadr ibn al-Harith — Banu ʿAbd al-Dar. Standard-bearer of Quraysh — his clan held the standard by hereditary right — and in Mecca the man who used to follow the Prophet's recitations with Persian romances to draw the crowd away. Taken alive; executed at al-Safra' on the road home, by ʿAli in most reports.†

Suhayl ibn ʿAmr — Banu ʿAmir ibn Luʾayy. Leader of his clan's contingent, and the orator of Quraysh. Taken prisoner; ʿUmar asked leave to pull out his front teeth so he could never speak against Islam again and was refused. Ransomed at four thousand dirhams. Became a Muslim at the conquest, and it was his speech that kept Mecca calm on the day the Prophet died.

Hakim ibn Hizam — Banu Asad ibn ʿAbd al-ʿUzza. Nephew of Khadija, and ʿUtba's messenger in the attempt to turn the army round; carried the proposal to the chiefs and then to Abu Jahl, who was oiling his mail and refused. Escaped the

field, became a Muslim at the conquest, and afterwards would not pass the site of Badr without hurrying his mount.

'Umayr ibn Wahb al-Jumahi — Banu Jumah. A hard-bitten raider, sent out on the morning of the battle to ride round the Muslim position: he came back with "three hundred men, a few more or a few less," rode out again to look for hidden supports, and reported none — and then warned the army that these were men with nothing to lose. His son Wahb was taken prisoner. Later a Muslim.

'Ikrima ibn Abi Jahl — Banu Makhzum. Fought beside his father; nearly severed Mu'adh ibn 'Amr's arm and killed Rafi' ibn al-Mu'alla. Fled the field. Became a Muslim after the conquest of Mecca and was killed fighting the Byzantines in Syria.

'Amir ibn al-Hadrami — a Hadrami client of Banu 'Abd Shams. Brother of the 'Amr killed at Nakhla the year before, whose blood was the standing pretext for the campaign. Put up by Abu Jahl to raise the feud-cry — *wa 'Amra!* — which killed 'Utba's peace proposal on the spot. Credited with the arrow that killed Mihja'. Killed in the melee.

Abu al-Bakhtari (al-'As ibn Hisham) — Banu Asad ibn 'Abd al-'Uzza. One of the Meccans who had worked to break the boycott of Banu Hashim, and one of those the Prophet would rather not have had killed. Offered quarter by al-Mujadhdhir and refused to take it while his companion was cut down beside him; killed. Thrown into the qalib.

al-Aswad ibn 'Abd al-Asad al-Makhzumi — Banu Makhzum. Swore he would drink from the Muslims' cistern or destroy it or die at it, and went forward alone to try; killed by Hamza — the first man of either side to fall. Thrown into the qalib.

Tu'ayma ibn 'Adi ibn Nawfal — Banu Nawfal. Killed by Hamza. His nephew Jubayr ibn Mut'im would later put Wahshi up to killing Hamza at Uhud in revenge. Thrown into the qalib.

al-Akhnas ibn Shariq — of Thaqif, confederate of Banu Zuhra. Turned the whole Zuhra contingent round at al-Juhfa and marched it home, which is why not one man of Banu Zuhra was killed or taken at Badr. He never became a Muslim.

Munabbih ibn al-Hajjaj — Banu Sahm. Joint leader of his clan's contingent with his brother. Killed by Abu al-Yasar Ka'b ibn 'Amr and the Ansar. Thrown into the qalib.

Nubayh ibn al-Hajjaj — Banu Sahm. Brother of Munabbih; killed by Abu Usayd Malik ibn Rabi'a and the Ansar. Thrown into the qalib.

Abu'l-'As ibn al-Rabi' — Banu 'Abd Shams. The Prophet's son-in-law, husband of his daughter Zaynab; taken prisoner, ransomed by his brother, and released on an undertaking to let Zaynab go to Medina, which he kept. Became a Muslim years later.

al-Walid ibn al-Walid ibn al-Mughira — Banu Makhzum. Brother of Khalid ibn al-Walid; ransomed at four thousand dirhams by his brothers, then became a Muslim immediately after and had to escape Mecca a second time.

Suhayl ibn Bayda' — Banu al-Harith ibn Fihr. Already a Muslim in secret and forced out with Quraysh; released without ransom when 'Abdallah ibn Mas'ud testified that he had prayed with them in Mecca.

The Fallen

The Fourteen

The Muslim dead. The number is fourteen in Ibn Ishaq and in al-Waqidi, and the division into six Muhajirun and eight Ansar is standard; a handful of later lists give eight and eight, or six and eight with ʿUbayda ibn al-Harith counted out because he died on the road rather than on the field. I keep him in, and keep the total at fourteen.

Muhajirun (6)

ʿUbayda ibn al-Harith · Banu al-Muttalib
Leg severed by **ʿUtba ibn Rabiʾa** in the opening single combat; died of the wound at **al-Safra'** on the return march and was buried there. The oldest of the fourteen.

ʿUmayr ibn Abi Waqqas · Banu Zuhra
About sixteen, younger brother of Saʾd; killed in the melee. Killer not named.

Dhu al-Shimalayn — ʿUmayr ibn ʿAbd ʿAmr · Khuzaʾa, confederate of Banu Zuhra
Killed in the fighting in the centre. Killer not named. His nickname means "the man of two left hands", or of two right hands, depending on the report.

ʿAqil ibn al-Bukayr · of Banu Saʾd ibn Layth, ally of Banu ʿAdi
Killed by **Malik ibn Zuhayr al-Jushami**.

Mihja', freedman of 'Umar ibn al-Khattab · client of Banu 'Adi
The first of the Muslims killed, hit by an arrow in the exchange before the lines closed; the shot attributed to **'Amir ibn al-Hadrami**.† A minority of reports give that place to Harith ibn Suraqa, below.

Safwan ibn Bayda' · Banu al-Harith ibn Fihr
Killed in the melee. Killer not named. Brother of the Suhayl ibn Bayda' who was on the other side and released without ransom.

Ansar (8) — Khazraj 6, Aws 2

'Awf ibn al-Harith ibn 'Afra · Khazraj — Banu al-Najjar
Killed by **Abu Jahl**, after stripping off his coat of mail and charging in without it.†

Mu'awwidh ibn al-Harith ibn 'Afra · Khazraj — Banu al-Najjar
Brother of 'Awf. He struck Abu Jahl where he lay crippled, went on into the Makhzumi press and was killed there, further inside the Qurayshi line than any other man of the fourteen; killer not named. Some lists give him to Abu Jahl as well, which cannot stand with the sequence followed in this book, Abu Jahl being already down when Mu'awwidh struck him.†

'Umayr ibn al-Humam · Khazraj — Banu Salima
Killed by **Khalid ibn al-A'lam**, having thrown away his handful of dates to charge the line.

Rafi' ibn al-Mu'alla · Khazraj — Banu Zurayq
Killed by **'Ikrima ibn Abi Jahl**.

Harith ibn Suraqa · Khazraj — Banu 'Adi ibn al-Najjar
Shot through the throat by **Hibban ibn al-'Ariqa** while he was drinking at the cistern behind the Muslim line.

Yazid ibn al-Harith ibn Fus-hum · Khazraj — Banu Balhubla
Killed by **Nawfal ibn Mu'awiya al-Dili**.

Sa'd ibn Khaythama · Aws — Banu 'Amr ibn 'Awf
Killed by **'Amr ibn 'Abd Wudd**.† He had drawn lots with his father for the place in the army.

Mubashshir ibn 'Abd al-Mundhir · Aws — Banu 'Amr ibn 'Awf
Killed by **Abu Thawr**.† Brother of Abu Lubaba, who had been turned back at al-Rawha' to hold Medina.

Two things are worth noticing about this list. The first is how young and how ordinary most of it is: one sixteen-year-old, two brothers of the same mother, a freed slave, a man shot while drinking. The second is the distribution. Six of the eight Ansar dead are Khazraj, which matches the Khazraj's larger share of the army; and thirteen of the fourteen fell on the field, in a battle that lasted a few hours of one morning.

*

The Well

After the fighting the Prophet ordered the Quraysh dead gathered and put into a dry well — a *qalib* — in the valley floor, and the mouth of it filled in. The sources name about twenty-four men thrown in, all of them of the chiefs and the notables; the remaining Quraysh dead were buried where they lay or left to their own people. Ibn Ishaq preserves the fullest list of names, al-Waqidi the fullest list of killers, and the two do not always agree. A dagger (†) marks an attribution the sources dispute — and a good many of them are disputed, because claiming a chief's death was a matter of clan honour for generations afterwards.

Abu Jahl ʻAmr ibn Hisham · Makhzum

Leg taken off at the shin by **Mu'adh ibn ʻAmr ibn al-Jamuh**; struck as he lay by **Mu'awwidh ibn ʻAfra**; found alive and beheaded by **ʻAbdallah ibn Mas'ud**.††† All three stages, and the order of them, are contested: Bukhari has a version in which Ibn Mas'ud alone finds and kills him, and other reports give the killing to Mu'adh outright or to the two sons of ʻAfra. The composite above is the reading this book follows.

ʻUtba ibn Rabi'a · ʻAbd Shams

Mortally wounded by **ʻUbayda ibn al-Harith** in the single combat and finished where he fell by **Hamza** and **ʻAli** together, which is the sequence this book follows; some reports credit the killing to ʻUbayda alone.†

Shayba ibn Rabi'a · ʻAbd Shams

Hamza ibn ʻAbd al-Muttalib in the single combat.

al-Walid ibn ʻUtba · ʻAbd Shams

ʻAli ibn Abi Talib in the single combat.

Umayya ibn Khalaf · Jumah

Cut down by **the Ansar** who came at Bilal ibn Rabah's shout, out of the hands of ʻAbd al-Rahman ibn ʻAwf, who had taken him prisoner and threw himself over the man to keep them off.† Variants make Bilal himself the killer.

ʻAli ibn Umayya ibn Khalaf · Jumah

Cut down by the Ansar together with his father.

al-ʻAs ibn Hisham ibn al-Mughira · Makhzum

ʻUmar ibn al-Khattab — his own maternal uncle, brother of his mother Hantama bint Hisham. Not to be confused with the other al-ʻAs ibn Hisham on this list, Abu al-Bakhtari of Banu Asad.

Nawfal ibn Khuwaylid ibn al-ʻAdawiyya · Asad

ʻAli ibn Abi Talib.† A minority report gives him to al-Zubayr.

al-Harith ibn ʻAmir ibn Nawfal · Nawfal
Khubayb ibn Isaf of the Ansar.

Tu'ayma ibn ʻAdi ibn Nawfal · Nawfal
Hamza ibn ʻAbd al-Muttalib.† Some reports name ʻAli.

Zam'a ibn al-Aswad ibn al-Muttalib · Asad
Thabit ibn al-Jidh' and the Ansar of the melee.†

al-Harith ibn Zam'a · Asad
Killed beside his father as the Quraysh right gave way; killer not named.

ʻAqil ibn al-Aswad · Asad
The Ansar on the Muslim left; killer not named.

Abu al-Bakhtari al-ʻAs ibn Hisham · Asad
al-Mujadhdhir ibn Dhiyad al-Balawi, against his will and after twice offering him quarter, which he would not take while his companion was killed.

Nubayh ibn al-Hajjaj · Sahm
Abu Usayd Malik ibn Rabi'a and the Ansar.†

Munabbih ibn al-Hajjaj · Sahm
Abu al-Yasar Ka'b ibn ʻAmr and the Ansar.† The two brothers' killers are sometimes swapped between reports.

al-ʻAs ibn Munabbih · Sahm
Killed with his father's men; killer not named.

ʻUbayda ibn Sa'id ibn al-ʻAs (Abu Dhat al-Karish) · ʻAbd Shams
al-Zubayr ibn al-ʻAwwam, speared through the eye-slit of his visor — the only opening in his armour. Al-Zubayr said afterwards that he had to put his foot on the man to work the spear free.

al-Aswad ibn ʿAbd al-Asad al-Makhzumi · Makhzum
Hamza ibn ʿAbd al-Muttalib — the first man of either side killed at Badr, at the cistern he had sworn to drink from or destroy, before the single combats began.

Hanzala ibn Abi Sufyan · ʿAbd Shams
ʿAli ibn Abi Talib.†

Abu Qays ibn al-Fakih ibn al-Mughira · Makhzum
The Muslim centre; killer not named.

Abu Qays ibn al-Walid ibn al-Mughira · Makhzum
The Muslim centre; killer not named.

Hisham ibn Abi Hudhayfa ibn al-Mughira · Makhzum
Killed among the Muhajirun's press; killer not named.†

ʿUmayr ibn ʿUthman ibn Kaʿb · Taym
Salit ibn Qays and the Khazraj.†

Two more Quraysh notables died at the Prophet's order on the road home rather than in the valley, and so are not in the well: **al-Nadr ibn al-Harith** of ʿAbd al-Dar, executed at al-Safra' — by ʿAli in the majority of reports, by al-Miqdad in others† — and **ʿUqba ibn Abi Muʿayt** of ʿAbd Shams, executed at ʿIrq al-Zabya by ʿAsim ibn Thabit al-Ansari in the better-attested version, by ʿAli in a competing one.†

The list above will not reconcile with the round seventy at every point, and it is not meant to. It is the class of the dead that the tradition kept accurately: twenty-four names of chiefs and notables, known because their families were known, set against a total that has the shape of an estimate.

Chronology

The anchor is 17 Ramadan 2 AH, converted by the standard tables to 13 March 624. Everything else here is counted forward and back from that day, and the arithmetic is the table's own, not the sources'.

The conversion needs one caveat stated plainly. The sources are unanimous that Badr was fought on a Friday, and 13 March 624 in the Julian calendar — which is the calendar the Near East actually kept in 624 — was a Tuesday. The mismatch is not a slip by anybody. Conversion tables run the Muslim calendar arithmetically, on alternating months of thirty and twenty-nine days from a fixed epoch, whereas the calendar of 624 was observational: each month began when a man saw the new crescent, and an overcast evening at Mecca could push a month a day late. Two or three days of accumulated drift over two years is entirely ordinary, and would put 17 Ramadan on Julian 16 March, a Friday. I keep 13 March because it is the figure the whole literature uses, and note that the true date was probably a day or three later. Readers who see "17 March 624" elsewhere are looking at the same day expressed in proleptic Gregorian reckoning, which did not exist yet.

Two warnings. First, the caravan's departure from Gaza is nowhere dated. A thousand camels moving south down the incense road at the thirty to thirty-five kilometres a day such a column could sustain would need five or six weeks for the journey, which puts Abu Sufyan out of Gaza in the first half of Sha'ban, a month before the battle; the entries before 1 Ramadan are therefore reconstruction and are marked as such. Second, the date of the

march out of Medina is itself disputed: one tradition gives 8 Ramadan, another 12 Ramadan, and Ibn Sa'd preserves both. This table follows 12 Ramadan, with the chapter. It is the more widely reported figure, and the distance does not argue against it: Badr is about eighty miles from Medina by the track, or a little over a hundred and thirty kilometres, which is five days at the twenty-five to thirty-five kilometres a day a column of men mostly on foot could keep up. The 8 Ramadan reckoning would leave nine days for that march, which is slow rather than impossible, and it has the further difficulty of putting the army at Badr several days before Quraysh could have got there. Where the two schemes differ, the events are fixed by their sequence and by the one certain date at the end of it, not by the day-numbers.

early Sha'ban 2 · early Feb 624

(reconstructed) Abu Sufyan ibn Harb turns the great caravan south out of **Gaza**: a thousand camels, some fifty thousand dinars' worth of cloth, silver and hides, the pooled investment of most Meccan households, and thirty-odd armed men. Its protection is speed and secrecy.

mid–late Sha'ban · mid–late Feb

(reconstructed) The caravan works down the Syrian road. In Medina the Prophet learns it is coming.

1 Ram · 26 Feb

The caravan somewhere north of Tabuk. Talha ibn 'Ubaydallah and Sa'id ibn Zayd are already out on the northern road watching for it.

5 Ram · 1 Mar

Abu Sufyan, working south and asking every traveller he meets for news of Medina, learns that Muhammad has called out his people to meet him. He hires **Damdam ibn ʻAmr al-Ghifari** and sends him on to Mecca at speed — three hundred miles and more. At Mecca, three days before Damdam arrives, **ʻAtika bint ʻAbd al-Muttalib** dreams of the rider who cries the alarm in the valley and the rock that splits over the city; al-ʻAbbas tells it, and Abu Jahl laughs at it.

8 Ram · 4 Mar

Damdam comes into the sanctuary standing on his camel's back, its ears slit and its saddle turned about and his shirt torn front and back, crying that the caravan is cut off. The **mala'** meets in the courtyard of the Ka'ba; the muster begins.

9–10 Ram · 5–6 Mar

Mecca marches: some 950 fighting men, 100 horses, 700 camels, with drummers, wineskins and singing-women behind. **Banu ʻAdi** refuse to send a man. Banu Hashim and Banu al-Muttalib are shamed into the column.

12 Ram · 8 Mar

The scouts' report has reached Medina and the Prophet puts the question to the assembly; Abu Bakr, ʻUmar and al-Miqdad speak for the march, then **Sa'd ibn Mu'adh** commits the Ansar — "if you took us into the sea we would plunge in with you." The army marches out the same day: **313 men, two horses, some 70 camels, 6 coats of mail, 8 swords**. **Ibn Umm Maktum** is left over the prayer in the city. The column halts at **Buyut al-Suqya** on the western edge of the oasis and is reviewed and counted; **Qays ibn Abi Sa'sa'a** is given the rear.

13 Ram · 9 Mar

The column reaches **al-Rawha'**. **Abu Lubaba ibn 'Abd al-Mundhir** is turned back to hold Medina; the under-age boys — 'Abdallah ibn 'Umar, al-Bara' ibn 'Azib, Zayd ibn Thabit and others — are sent home.

14 Ram · 10 Mar

The Prophet leaves the Mecca trunk road at **al-Munsarif** and turns onto the Badr track, so as not to be seen. The Quraysh army, moving north-west, reaches **al-Juhfa**: Abu Sufyan's message arrives there — the goods are safe, go home — and **al-Akhnas ibn Shariq** turns the whole Banu Zuhra contingent round and marches it back — perhaps a hundred men, perhaps three times that; not one of them was at Badr. Abu Jahl refuses to turn.

15 Ram · 11 Mar

The Muslims at **al-Safra'**, a village of palms between two hills; from here **Basbas ibn 'Amr** and **'Adi ibn Abi'l-Zaghba'**, both of Juhayna, are sent ahead to the wells of Badr to find the caravan. Quraysh press on past **al-Abwa'**. Abu Sufyan, having had no word back, swings the caravan hard west onto the **coast road** and takes it past Badr with the wadi on his left.

16 Ram · 12 Mar · day

The two scouts lie up at the well of Badr and overhear two women arguing over a debt, one promising to pay when the caravan arrives the next day; they carry the news back. In the valley of **Dhafiran** the other word arrives — that Quraysh have come out of Mecca in force. The expedition stops being a raid on a caravan. The Prophet consults the army, and it commits to battle. At the last halt short of the ridge **'Utba ibn Rabi'a** tries to buy the army off through **Hakim ibn Hizam**, offering the Hadrami blood-money himself; Abu Jahl breaks it, and **'Amir ibn al-Hadrami** raises the blood-cry for his brother. Quraysh then cross **al-'Aqanqal** and camp in the hollows of the far, soft bank at **'Udwat al-Quswa**.

16 Ram · 12 Mar · evening

The Muslims halt short of the valley. **Two Quraysh water-carriers** are taken at the wells and, beaten and then questioned properly, give the strength and the names: the chiefs are all present. The Prophet: "This is Mecca; she has thrown you the pieces of her own liver."

16 Ram · 12 Mar · night

al-Hubab ibn al-Mundhir asks whether the halting-place is revelation or judgement; told it is judgement, he urges pushing on to the nearest well of Badr, holding it and wrecking the rest. The army moves up in the dark, seizes the near bank and builds the **hawd**. Rain falls in the night: it packs the gravel hard on the Muslim side and makes the loose sand under al-'Aqanqal slump and hold water. The **'arish** is built.

17 Ram · 13 Mar · before dawn

Ibn Ishaq reports a sleep falling on the Muslim camp, and the Prophet praying much of the night at the foot of a tree. Scouts probe the far bank.

17 Ram · 13 Mar · dawn

Dawn prayer; the address to the army; the ranks dressed with an arrow-shaft, and the exchange with **Sawad ibn Ghaziyya**. **Mus'ab ibn 'Umayr** takes the white liwa'.

17 Ram · 13 Mar · after sunrise

Quraysh come up out of the dune hollows onto the open valley floor and deploy. **'Umayr ibn Wahb** rides a circuit of the Muslim camp and reports three hundred and no hidden supports, and warns the chiefs what they are facing; Abu Jahl overrides him as he had overridden 'Utba.

17 Ram · 13 Mar · mid-morning

al-Aswad al-Makhzumi goes for the cistern and is killed by Hamza — the first man of either side down. The **mubaraza**: ʿUbayda ibn al-Harith, Hamza and ʿAli against ʿUtba, Shayba and al-Walid; all three Quraysh champions are killed, ʿUbayda crippled. Then the archery exchange across the closing gap; **Mihja'** falls, the first of the Muslim dead.

17 Ram · 13 Mar · late morning

The lines close. The Prophet throws the handful of dust — "let the faces be disfigured" — and orders the general advance. The Quraysh centre holds around Abu Jahl, then breaks. **Umayya ibn Khalaf** is cut down out of ʿAbd al-Rahman ibn ʿAwf's hands. **Abu Jahl** loses a leg to Mu'adh ibn ʿAmr, is struck where he lies by Mu'awwidh ibn ʿAfra, and is found alive and beheaded by Ibn Mas'ud. The army runs for al-ʿAqanqal; the pursuit takes prisoners rather than lives.

17 Ram · 13 Mar · afternoon

The field cleared: **about seventy Quraysh dead and seventy taken**, against **fourteen Muslim dead**. The dispute over the spoils.

17 Ram · 13 Mar · dusk

The Quraysh chiefs put into the **qalib** and the mouth filled in; the Prophet's words at the pit. The Muslim dead buried at the edge of the field. Night at Badr.

18 Ram · 14 Mar

A day at Badr: the spoils gathered and guarded, the prisoners bound and fed, the wounded seen to. The first fugitives are already on the Mecca road with the news; **al-Haysuman al-Khuza'i** brings it into the city and is thought to have lost his mind until he starts naming the dead, and Abu Lahab hears the account of the day from **Abu Sufyan ibn al-Harith**.

19 Ram · 15 Mar

The army marches north-east up the wadi to **al-Safra'**, a valley of palms a day out of Badr. **'Ubayda ibn al-Harith** dies of his wound and is buried there. **al-Nadr ibn al-Harith** is brought out of the column and put to death.

20 Ram · 16 Mar

The column reaches **al-Rawha'**, some twenty-five miles short of Medina. **Zayd ibn Haritha** on the Prophet's own al-Qaswa' and **'Abdallah ibn Rawaha** are sent ahead as heralds. The prisoners are watered and fed; the men of Medina give them bread and eat dates themselves.

21 Ram · 17 Mar

Still at or leaving al-Rawha'. The heralds reach Medina and the city comes out; the news is at first disbelieved, then the prisoners' names are read out.

22 Ram · 18 Mar

The column passes **'Irq al-Zabya**, where **'Uqba ibn Abi Mu'ayt** is put to death, and halts at **al-Ruhayya**.

23 Ram · 19 Mar

Through **Sayer** and **Turban**, the last stages on the Mecca road.

24 Ram · 20 Mar

Into **al-'Aqiq** on the edge of the oasis, where the army forms up, and then into **Medina** — thirteen days out, something over a hundred and sixty miles marched, there and back. The prisoners are distributed among the households; the division of the spoils and the ruling of Surat al-Anfal follow within days, as does the council on the prisoners' fate.

Numbers and Distances

Distances through this chapter are given in miles. The Arabic sources reckon in the *barid* (about twelve miles) and the day's march; Badr is placed by the geographers at four *barid* or thereabouts from the coast, and it lies about seventy miles direct from Medina and about eighty by the track, the road being longer than the straight line because it bends (note 25). Eighty miles is also the round figure used throughout this chapter for the distance from the oasis to the nearest point of the caravan route, which happens to run close to Badr; it is an order of magnitude and not a surveyed length.

Glossary

al- — the Arabic definite article, "the", prefixed to nouns and to many names: *al-Zubayr*, *al-'Abbas*, *al-Hubab*. It is part of the name and does not affect alphabetisation in this book. In speech the *l* is often swallowed into the following consonant, so *al-Nadr* is said *an-Nadr* and *al-Safra'* is said *as-Safra'*.

Ansar — "the Helpers": the Muslims of Medina, natives of the oasis, who had invited the Prophet north and who housed and fed the emigrants from Mecca. At Badr they made up something over two-thirds of the army, and their willingness to fight a battle outside their own territory — which the original agreement had not required of them — was the question the council before the march existed to settle. They fell into two large tribal blocs, Aws and Khazraj.

'arish — a shelter of branches, palm-fronds and cloth, thrown up in an hour. At Badr one was built for the Prophet on a rise a hundred and fifty paces behind the centre of his line, on Sa'd ibn Mu'adh's suggestion, with a guard on it and a camel kept saddled beside it. It was not a command post in any modern sense; it was shade, and a place to pray from.

Aws — one of the two great Arab tribal blocs of Medina, the smaller of the two, settled mainly in the southern and eastern quarters of the oasis. Sa'd ibn Mu'adh's Banu 'Abd al-Ashhal were Aws. Two of the fourteen Muslim dead at Badr were Aws.

diya — blood-money: the compensation in camels or silver that a killer's kin paid to the dead man's kin to close a feud without further killing. It was the

mechanism that kept Arabian society from bleeding itself out, and it is why ʿUtba ibn Rabiʾa's offer to pay the diya for ʿAmr al-Hadrami out of his own wealth was a serious proposal and not a gesture: it would have removed the campaign's legal pretext at a stroke.

fidya — ransom. At Badr the ransoms for the seventy prisoners were assessed between one thousand and four thousand dirhams a head according to a man's wealth and standing; prisoners too poor to pay but able to write were released for teaching ten children of Medina their letters, and some were released for nothing.

ghanima — the spoils of a raid or a battle: weapons, mail, mounts, cloth, silver, and the prisoners. Pre-Islamic custom gave the taker what he took. The disputes over the division at Badr, and the ruling that followed in Surat al-Anfal — a fifth set aside and the rest shared out — mark the point at which a tribal practice became a state's revenue.

hawd — a cistern or watering-trough. Al-Hubab ibn al-Mundhir's advice was to seize the nearest well of Badr and build a hawd at it, so that the whole army could drink from a standing reservoir rather than queue at the well-head. Two of the day's deaths happened at it.

hijra — the emigration of 622, when the Prophet and some seventy Meccan households left Mecca for Medina. The Muslim calendar counts its years from it: 2 AH, the year of Badr, is the second year after the hijra. Those who made the move are the **Muhajirun**.

ibn / bint — "son of" and "daughter of"; *ibn* is often abbreviated *b.* in scholarly writing. ʿUtba ibn Rabiʾa is ʿUtba, son of Rabiʾa, and ʿAtika bint ʿAbd al-Muttalib is ʿAtika, daughter of ʿAbd al-Muttalib. A chain of them gives a pedigree, so al-ʿAs ibn Hisham ibn al-Mughira is al-ʿAs, son of Hisham, son of al-Mughira. Arabic names carry no fixed surname, and a man is identified by his father, his clan, or his

kunya — which is why two different men at Badr can both be called al-ʻAs ibn Hisham and be no relation.

isnad — the chain of transmitters attached to a report, naming who heard it from whom back to an eyewitness. It is the central instrument of Muslim historical criticism and it does real work: it lets the sources be graded, and it makes wholesale invention difficult. It does not eliminate embellishment, since a sound chain can carry a story that grew in the telling, and it says nothing about a transmitter's memory for numbers.

Khazraj — the larger of Medina's two Arab tribal blocs, settled mainly in the central and western quarters of the oasis and subdivided into clans of its own, of which Banu al-Najjar, Banu Salima, Banu Zurayq and Banu Sa'ida all sent men to Badr. Something like 170 of the 313 were Khazraj — more than half the army — and six of the fourteen Muslim dead. The Aws and the Khazraj had fought each other for generations, most recently and most bloodily at Bu'ath five years before the hijra; that they stood in one line at Badr was itself recent and fragile, and the sources let the old rivalry show in the competition over who had done most on the day.

kunya — the by-name formed with *Abu*, "father of", or *Umm*, "mother of": Abu Bakr, Abu Sufyan, Abu Jahl. Most were affectionate or descriptive rather than literal. *Abu Jahl*, "father of ignorance", is not one of these: it is a Muslim nickname that stuck so hard it displaced the man's real name, ʻAmr ibn Hisham, from the record almost entirely.

liwa' / raya — the two kinds of standard. The *liwa'* was the army's single principal banner, tied to a lance-head and carried near the commander; the *raya* was a smaller flag borne by a contingent. At Badr Mus'ab ibn ʻUmayr carried the white liwa'; there was a black raya with ʻAli and another with the Ansar. Losing a standard was a public disaster, and the men who carried them were expected to die before dropping them.

mail, coat of mail (*dir'*) — a shirt of interlinked iron rings, sometimes with a hood and sleeves, worn over padding. It was the single most expensive thing a fighting man could own, worth many camels, and it was very effective against a cut and only fair against a thrust. The Muslims at Badr had six between three hundred and thirteen men; a good part of the Quraysh nobility was in mail from the throat down, which is why the sources make so much of finding the gaps.

mala' — the assembly of the chiefs of Quraysh: the heads of the clans who met in the courtyard beside the Ka'ba and decided Mecca's affairs by consensus, having no king and no standing army. The Qur'an and the sira both use the word for the men who ran Mecca, and Badr took most of them off the board in a single morning.

maghazi — the genre of Arabic writing devoted to the Prophet's expeditions, campaign by campaign; al-Waqidi's *Kitab al-Maghazi* is the classic of it. The maghazi are richer in circumstantial detail than the general biographies and correspondingly more suspect for it: the detail had a century and more in which to accumulate.

mubaraza — single combat before the general engagement. Champions stepped out of the line, named themselves, and fought in view of both armies. It was a real form of battle and not a formality: it could settle the day's temper, and at Badr it did, since all three Quraysh champions were of one family and all three were killed.

Muhajirun — "the Emigrants": the Meccan Muslims who had left their city, their clans and mostly their property for Medina. At Badr they numbered somewhere between seventy-four and eighty-six of the army, and they were fighting their own fathers, brothers and uncles, which the sources never let the reader forget.

qalib — a dry or disused well: a shaft, sometimes lined, going down to a level the water has left. The Quraysh dead at Badr were put into one and its mouth filled in.

Quraysh — the tribe that held Mecca and its sanctuary, divided into a dozen or so clans — Hashim, ʿAbd Shams, Makhzum, Jumah, Sahm, Nawfal, ʿAbd al-Dar, Asad, Taym, ʿAdi, Zuhra, ʿAmir — which competed, intermarried and quarrelled and which acted together only when they had to. The Prophet was Qurayshi, of Banu Hashim; so was almost every man in the line opposite him. Badr was in that sense a family quarrel fought with weapons.

Ramadan — the ninth month of the Muslim year, in which the fast from dawn to sunset is kept. Badr was fought on the seventeenth of it, in a valley, in March, by men who had marched eighty miles to get there. Whether the army kept the fast on the day itself is disputed in the sources; this book takes it that they did, no licence to break it having yet been given.

sira — the biography of the Prophet as a literary form. Ibn Ishaq's *Sirat Rasul Allah*, which survives through Ibn Hisham's edited recension, is the foundation of the genre and the oldest continuous narrative we have of Badr.

sunna — the Prophet's practice: what he did, said and permitted, taken by Muslims as normative alongside the Qur'an. It matters to the sources' shape, because a report about Badr was very often preserved not for its historical interest but because a legal ruling hung on it — the division of spoils, the treatment of prisoners, prayer on campaign.

wadi — a valley cut by water that runs only after rain: dry sand or gravel most of the year, a torrent for a few hours after a storm, with a water table close enough beneath the surface for wells and palms. Badr sits in one. The wadi's two banks, the soft sand on the Quraysh side and the firmer ground on the Muslim side, decided much of the battle.

Further Reading

Ibn Ishaq, *Sirat Rasul Allah*, in Ibn Hisham's recension. In English as A. Guillaume, *The Life of Muhammad* (Oxford, 1955), still the standard translation; the Badr material runs from roughly p. 289 to p. 360. The oldest continuous narrative of the battle and the spine of every account since, including this one. Read it knowing what it is: a work of the 760s, surviving only in the edited version an Egyptian scholar made of it sixty years later, by an author his own contemporaries in Medina accused of credulity about Jewish and south-Arabian material and of taking reports from unreliable men. Guillaume prints Ibn Hisham's own notes separately at the back, which is worth the flipping.

al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, ed. Marsden Jones (3 vols, Oxford, 1966); English as Rizwi Faizer et al., *The Life of Muhammad: al-Waqidi's Kitab al-Maghazi* (Routledge, 2011). Fullest on the ground at Badr by a distance: who stood where, what the wells were called, the state of the sand, the names of killers. It is indispensable and it is the source you should trust least where it is most vivid, because the precision arrives a generation after Ibn Ishaq's and nobody can say from where.

Ibn Sa'd, *Kitab al-Tabaqat al-Kabir*. The Badr expedition in vol. 2; the biographies of the participants in vols 3 and 4, which is where the clan affiliations and the death-dates in the roster above mostly come from. Not a narrative — a card index, and enormously useful as one, because it lets you check a man's clan without taking a storyteller's word for it.

al-Tabari, *Tarikh al-Rusul wa'l-Muluk*, English as *The History of al-Tabari*, vol. 7, *The Foundation of the Community*, trans. W. Montgomery Watt and M. V. McDonald (SUNY, 1987). Al-Tabari's method is to lay variant reports side by side with their chains and let the reader judge, which makes him the single best place to see what the disagreements over Badr actually look like before a modern author tidies them.

Sahih al-Bukhari and Sahih Muslim, *Kitab al-Maghazi* and *Kitab al-Jihad*. Short, disconnected reports, but the most rigorously screened material we have, and on some points decisive: Ibn Mas'ud on finding Abu Jahl, 'Abd al-Rahman ibn 'Awf on losing Umayya ibn Khalaf, the counting of the army. Useless for the shape of the day and invaluable for particular moments in it.

The Qur'an, Surat al-Anfal (8) entire, and Al 'Imran 3:121-129. The earliest layer by two centuries and the only one contemporary with the event, and the hardest to use, because it alludes rather than narrates: it addresses people who were there and needed nothing explained. It nonetheless fixes several things the histories only report — the dispute over the spoils, the reluctance of some to march, the rebuke over the ransoms.

Ibn Kathir, *al-Bidaya wa'l-Nihaya* and his ***al-Sira al-Nabawiyya*** (English trans. Trevor Le Gassick, 4 vols, Garnet, 1998-2000). A fourteenth-century synthesis that quotes its predecessors at length and argues between them with a hadith critic's instincts. The most convenient single place to find the variant reports gathered with an assessment attached, if you accept the assessor's premises.

W. Montgomery Watt, *Muhammad at Medina* (Oxford, 1956). The classic Western reconstruction, and the sharpest thinking anyone has done about what the Badr expedition was for in terms of the caravan economy and the politics of the oasis. Dated in idiom, occasionally too confident that a material motive must underlie a religious one, and still the book to argue with.

Martin Lings, ***Muhammad: His Life Based on the Earliest Sources*** (Islamic Texts Society, 1983). A narrative retelling, beautifully written, faithful to Ibn Ishaq and al-Waqidi and almost entirely uncritical of them: it harmonises where the sources conflict rather than reporting the conflict. Read for the shape of the story and not for adjudication.

Fred M. Donner, ***Muhammad and the Believers: At the Origins of Islam*** (Harvard, 2010), with his earlier *Narratives of Islamic Origins* (Darwin, 1998). Donner takes the source-critical objections seriously without concluding that nothing can be known, and *Narratives* is the best account of how the maghazi literature came to be written and what that does to its reliability.

Patricia Crone, ***Meccan Trade and the Rise of Islam*** (Princeton, 1987). Sceptical, sometimes corrosive, and essential background for anyone tempted to build an argument on the value of Abu Sufyan's caravan: Crone's attack on the standard picture of Mecca as a great trading city is not wholly persuasive but it cannot be ignored.

Safi al-Rahman al-Mubarakpuri, ***Ar-Raheeq Al-Makhtum*** **(The Sealed Nectar)** (Riyadh, various editions). A modern devotional synthesis, widely read, with the clearest simple maps and marching-tables of the campaign in print. Openly committed and not source-critical; useful for orientation and for the geography, and to be checked against the classical texts on anything contested.

Notes

1 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the raid on the caravan of Quraysh; the wording of Abu Sufyan's exclamation is usually given as "By God, this is the fodder of Yathrib." al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, has the same episode with Majdi ibn 'Amr al-Juhani present at the well. The detail is small, circumstantial and to nobody's theological advantage — Quraysh's caravan-master is made to look competent by it — and it is the kind of report that survives because someone remembered it rather than because it proved anything. Date-stones in the dung: dates were standard camel fodder in the Medinan oasis and were not fed to beasts on the Meccan road, which is what makes the inference work. (p. 1)

2 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the raid on the caravan of Quraysh; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, is fuller on the forced night march down the coastal strip without a watering halt. On the sources' testimony Abu Sufyan had been questioning travellers about Medina at every stage of the return, having been hunted on the outward leg at al-'Ushayra; see note 7. (p. 1)

3 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the chapters on the Emigration; Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, i and iii (the biographies of individual emigrants), where the loss of Meccan property recurs as a formula in the notices of the Muhajirun. The general fact of confiscation is not in dispute in the tradition; the individual cases are told in family-tradition mode and the details of who took what should be held loosely. (p. 2)

4 On the camel-load: the standard Arabian pack-load of the period is usually reckoned at something between two hundred and fifty and three hundred and fifty pounds, and the figure in the text is a round middle. On the shareholding: Ibn Hisham makes the point that there was scarcely a man or woman of Quraysh with ten dinars to invest who had nothing in this caravan — the observation matters for the muster

described in "Three Hundred and Thirteen," since it explains why the alarm produced a general muster rather than a rescue party. (p. 2)

5 Fred M. Donner, "Mecca's Food Supplies and Muhammad's Boycott," argues that Medina's expeditions towards the coast road were aimed at Mecca's grain supply from Syria and constituted an economic blockade, and that this, rather than the recovery of confiscated property or a general state of war, is the frame in which the raids of 1–2 AH make sense. W. Montgomery Watt, *Muhammad at Medina*, ch. 1, reads the raids as the ordinary practice of a new polity establishing itself by *ghazw*, with the Meccan trade the obvious object because it was the only thing worth taking. The two readings are not exclusive. The sources themselves offer no economic argument at all: they present the expeditions as attempts to come at Qurayshi property, and the chapter follows them in that, while noting that the Meccan reaction — a muster of the whole town — is more intelligible if Quraysh believed the road itself was at stake. (p. 3)

6 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the sections on the raids preceding Badr; Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids), which gives the fullest list and the dates by month; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, the expeditions before Badr. The lists do not agree in order or in leadership — Hamza ibn 'Abd al-Muttalib, 'Ubayda ibn al-Harith and Sa'd ibn Abi Waqqas are variously credited with the earliest of the sea-coast parties — and the discrepancies are the ordinary kind produced by clan traditions each claiming a first. Whether these expeditions were raids that failed or reconnaissance that succeeded is a real question. Their small size (some as few as eight men), their instructions in some reports to observe rather than engage, and the fact that they repeatedly reached the road just after a caravan had passed, all suggest that the earliest of them were probing the route and its rhythm; but Waddan and al-'Ushayra were led by the Prophet in person with a hundred and fifty to two hundred men and cannot be anything but attempts at interception. The reasonable reading is a progression: patrols first, interceptions after, with the knowledge gathered by the first making the second possible. The pursuit of Kurz ibn Jabir to Safawan has a further consequence for the battle — it took the Prophet and a core of his companions over the ground at Badr months before they had to fight on it. (p. 3)

7 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the raid of ʿAbdallah ibn Jahsh at Nakhla; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, the raid of Nakhla; Ibn Saʿd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids). The number of the party is given as eight or as twelve; the sealed-orders detail is in Ibn Ishaq and is repeated by everyone after him. Q 2:217 ("They ask you about the sacred month, about fighting in it") is referred by the exegetes to this episode, which is itself evidence that the Meccan complaint had to be answered. The victim's name is ʿAmr ibn al-Hadrami; his brother ʿAmir survived him and is heard from again in "The Valley of Yalyal." (p. 4)

8 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the raid on the caravan of Quraysh, gives a thousand camels and thirty men; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, has forty men and in one place a smaller figure for the animals, and the "seven hundred camels" of some later retellings looks like contamination from the count of the Meccan army's own camels, for which see "The Valley of Yalyal." The valuation — fifty thousand dinars, or in some reports fifty thousand *mithqals* of gold — should be read as a round number meaning "an enormous sum" rather than as an accounting figure; it appears in the sources in exactly the places where a storyteller needs to convey scale, and there is no plausible chain by which a Medinan tradition would have known the caravan's books. A thousand camels is the figure this chapter follows, with the caution that it too is round. What is not in doubt is the ratio: a very large cargo under a very small guard. See also §3 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 4)

9 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the raid on the caravan of Quraysh; the two watchers are Talha ibn ʿUbaydallah and Saʿid ibn Zayd, and Ibn Ishaq has them sheltered at al-Hawraʾ by Kashd al-Juhani. Their absence from Medina on this errand is the reason both men were away from the battle itself — a detail the tradition preserves against its own interest, since both were later of the highest standing and a fabricator would have put them in the valley. (p. 4)

10 Q 8:5–7 is the earliest layer of evidence on the object of the expedition and is quoted and argued at note 24. The narrative sources agree with the verse against their own later habits: Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the raid on the caravan of Quraysh, describes the muster in Medina as a call to go out against Abu Sufyan's caravan and nothing else, and al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, is the

same. al-Mubarakpuri, *Ar-Raheeq Al-Makhtum*, "The Battle of Badr," reads the expedition as an interception that turned into a battle, which is also Watt's reading in *Muhammad at Medina*, ch. 1. (p. 5)

11 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the muster of Quraysh; and see al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, who adds that Damdam was hired for the errand and gives the wording of the cry with small variations. The mutilation of the messenger's beast and the reversal of saddle and shirt are described by the sources as a recognised signal rather than explained, which suggests the practice was still legible to their first audiences; al-Waqidi alone specifies the bloodied nose. Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids), compresses the whole episode into a sentence. (p. 6)

12 Ibn Ishaq, in Guillaume, *The Life of Muhammad*, 290–291 (the dream of 'Atika and Abu Jahl's reply). The report comes through Hashimite channels — it is 'Atika's dream, told to al-'Abbas, and the punchline is al-'Abbas scoring off Abu Jahl in public — and its shape is suspiciously perfect: the dream-rider does precisely what Damdam then did, three days later, in the same valley. Family tradition of the 'Abbasid period had every reason to preserve and polish a story in which the Prophet's own house saw the disaster coming and the leader of Makhzum sneered at the warning. Against dismissing it altogether: the tradition also records a closely parallel dream by a Meccan of no such lineage, Juhaym ibn al-Salt, at a halt on the march, with Abu Jahl making almost the same joke — which suggests that dream-omens circulating in the Meccan column before Badr are a genuine memory even if the individual dreams have been worked up. This account narrates 'Atika's dream as Ibn Ishaq narrates it and takes no view on what she saw. (p. 7)

13 al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, is the fullest on the mechanics of the levy: the clan quotas, the substitution rule, the suspension of debts. Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the march of Quraysh, gives the clan contingents without the administrative detail. (p. 7)

14 al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, for the drums, the singing-women, the hundred horses and the six hundred to seven hundred camels; the feeding rota of nine or ten camels a day, on which the count of the army turns (note 30), is in both Ibn Ishaq and al-Waqidi. Al-Waqidi's Meccan equipment figures (commonly given as six or seven hundred coats of mail) are of the same suspiciously symmetrical kind as

his six on the Muslim side, and are best read as a statement of proportion rather than an inventory. (p. 7)

15 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the muster of Quraysh, for Abu Lahab's substitute and the four thousand dirhams; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, adds that al-'As's debt was owed for gambling. Ibn Hisham preserves the tradition that Abu Lahab also relied on the dream-omens as a pretext. The figure 4,000 dirhams is the same sum that recurs as a standard ransom for a prisoner after the battle, which may mean it was simply the going rate for a man of standing, or may mean that one round number has attracted the other. (p. 7)

16 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the march of Quraysh, on Banu 'Adi ibn Ka'b; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, is more explicit that the clan stayed home as a body. The absence is a genuine datum and not a courtesy to 'Umar's people: the sources are equally frank that Banu 'Adi produced no martyr and no prisoner on either side. (p. 7)

17 Ibn Ishaq, in Guillaume, *The Life of Muhammad*, 292 (Umayya ibn Khalaf, the censer and the kohl-stick). The insult works by assigning a man the two visible marks of a woman's toilet, incense and eye-paint, in front of his clan; al-Waqidi has the same scene with 'Uqba saying the words in the assembly rather than setting the objects down. Umayya's own reason for staying is given variously as age, weight, and specific fear of the Medinan side, he having been Bilal's owner and tormentor in Mecca. (p. 8)

18 The count. Three hundred and thirteen is the figure of Ibn Ishaq, al-Waqidi and Ibn Sa'd, and it is what Bukhari's reports of the men of Badr assume; the variants are 314, 317 and 319 in scattered reports, and a minority 307. Some of the spread is bookkeeping — whether to count Abu Lubaba, sent back from al-Rawha' to hold Medina but given a share of the spoils, and Talha ibn 'Ubaydallah and Sa'id ibn Zayd, who were away on the northern road and reached Medina after the army had gone, all three of whom were reckoned *badri* afterwards. The internal breakdown most often given, and the only one that sums without a remainder, is 82 or 83 Muhajirun, 61 of Aws and 170 of Khazraj. That the number matches the three hundred and thirteen who crossed the river with Saul in the Islamic retelling of the story of Gideon's band was noticed early and has been used to argue that the figure is

a topos; but 313 is an awkward number to invent, the badri lists are long and circumstantial, and the parallel was drawn later commentators rather than by the earliest reporters. See Bukhari, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Maghazi, bab of the number of the men of Badr. (p. 8)

19 The equipment. Two horses is the general report, with al-Zubayr ibn al-'Awwam and al-Miqdad ibn 'Amr named as the riders; a minority of reports make it three and give the third to Marthad ibn Abi Marthad. Seventy camels, sometimes seventy-odd, is stable across the sources. Six coats of mail and eight swords come from al-Waqidi, and they are the kind of figure a historian should hold at arm's length: they are exactly small, exactly memorable, and they serve a point the tradition wanted made. What supports them is the substance rather than the arithmetic — the Muslim army fought largely with bows, spears, stones and clubs, and the sources record particular weapons as individually notable in a way that would be absurd if there had been two hundred swords in the ranks. This account takes six and eight as round and rhetorical and the poverty they describe as real. al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr; Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids). See also §9 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 8)

20 al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, for the camel-rotation and the Prophet's refusal of the whole ride; Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids), names 'Ali ibn Abi Talib and Marthad ibn Abi Marthad as his partners, with Zayd ibn Haritha in some versions. Ibn Ishaq gives the three banners and the arrangements for Medina: Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the departure for Badr. (p. 8)

21 Ibn Ishaq, in Guillaume, *The Life of Muhammad*, 294 (the consultation and al-Miqdad's speech); Muslim, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Jihad wa'l-Siyar, preserves a version of the consultation from Anas ibn Malik in which al-Miqdad is the speaker for the Muhajirun and Sa'd for the Ansar. Whether the scene is one occasion or a composite is a fair question: the sources place the consultation at Dhafiran but the final commitment nearer the water, and the two lie about ten miles apart on the same stage of the march, so the accounts may have gathered into one meeting a discussion that ran over a day. The Qur'anic allusion at Q 8:5–6 to believers disputing after the matter was made clear to them implies argument, not a single tidy assent, which is a reason for thinking the debate real and its arrangement into set speeches later. al-

Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, adds speakers and lengthens the speeches, in his usual manner. (p. 9)

22 Ibn Ishaq, in Guillaume, *The Life of Muhammad*, 294 (Sa'd ibn Mu'adh's speech). A substantial minority tradition, followed by al-Waqidi and by Ibn Sa'd in one place, gives the speech to Sa'd ibn 'Ubada, chief of Khazraj. Sa'd ibn Mu'adh is to be preferred: he was chief of the Aws, he appears repeatedly in the battle narrative — proposing the shelter, commanding its guard — and Sa'd ibn 'Ubada is absent from the badri lists altogether — the reports that he was excused for illness or for a snakebite look like an attempt to account for the absence of a man whose eminence made his absence surprising. The likeliest explanation of the doublet is the shared name and the later prominence of Khazraj in Medina. The "if you went into the sea" clause appears in both versions and in a third, attributed to al-Miqdad, which suggests it was a formula of assent rather than one man's coinage. The pledge at 'Aqaba and its territorial limits: Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the second 'Aqaba; and see Watt, *Muhammad at Medina*, ch. 1, on the pact's terms. See also §12 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 10)

23 Q 8:5–7, revealed after the battle and looking back at the expedition's object: "as He brought you out of your house in truth, while a party of the believers were averse; disputing with you about the truth after it was made clear, as though they were being driven to death while they looked on; and when God promised you one of the two parties, that it should be yours, and you wished that it were the one without strength." It is the hardest passage in the whole dossier to explain away, since it concedes reluctance and a preference for plunder over battle, and no later apologist invents a rebuke that has the Companions setting out after baggage camels and vexed to find a war instead. Later exegesis softens "the one without strength" by making the preference prudential rather than acquisitive; the plain sense is the caravan. Ibn Kathir, *al-Bidaya wa'l-Nihaya*, iii, assembles the reports on the occasion of the verses. See also §4 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 10)

24 For the topography I follow the descriptions in Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the expedition to Badr, and al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, checked against the modern site. Badr lies at roughly 23° 47′ N, 38° 47′ E, some seventy miles direct from Medina and about eighty by the track, and about a

hundred and seventy-five miles direct from Mecca. Yalyal is the parent drainage; its upstream reach nearer Medina is Wadi al-Safra', and the sources use the two names loosely. al-Waqidi is the fullest on the ground at Badr and is the source for most of the small circumstantial detail here; he is also the source one should be most careful with, precisely because circumstantial detail is what a good storyteller supplies. Where his topography can be checked against the site it holds up, which is a point in his favour. (p. 11)

25 On the wells in the plural and on the filling of the surplus wells, Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of Badr; the operation described there is not possible with a single well. The water table at Badr stands a few fathoms below the sand — an Arab well of this kind is a shaft of one to two fathoms' collar and four to eight of depth, worked with a bucket and rope. (p. 11)

26 Q 8:42, *al-'udwa al-dunya* and *al-'udwa al-quswa*, the nearer and the farther bank, with the caravan "below you". The verse is the earliest layer of evidence for the battlefield's geometry and independently confirms the arrangement the narrative sources describe: the Muslims on the Medina side, Quraysh on the Mecca side, the caravan lower down toward the sea. (p. 12)

27 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of Badr, names 'Ali, al-Zubayr and Sa'd ibn Abi Waqqas as the party. al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, gives the two water-carriers as Aslam, a slave of Banu al-Hajjaj, and Abu Yasar, a slave of Banu al-'As; Ibn Ishaq names one or neither depending on the recension. I have kept Aslam, whose name is the better attested of the two. (p. 12)

28 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of Badr, for the beating and the rebuke; the report is also in al-Tabari, *Tarikh*, the year 2 AH, and in Ibn Kathir, *al-Bidaya wa'l-Nihaya*, iii, and Muslim, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Jihad wa'l-Siyar, preserves a related tradition on the questioning of the Badr water-carriers. That the beating is remembered at all, and remembered as a rebuke to the Muslims, is a small but useful indication that this material was not wholly smoothed. The wording of the Prophet's deduction from the camels varies: "between nine hundred and a thousand" is the common form, and al-Waqidi has a version in which the arithmetic is done for the reader. (p. 12)

29 The fullest of the chapter's disputes, and worth setting out. Four figures are in play. (i) Ibn Ishaq's, arrived at by the camel-and-loaves calculation: between nine hundred and a thousand. (ii) The round "one thousand", which is what most later writers give and what Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids), reports; it is almost certainly the Mecca muster figure rather than the field figure, and round thousands in this literature are estimates dressed as counts. (iii) al-Waqidi's clan-by-clan tallies, which are the most impressive-looking evidence and the least trustworthy, since they sum to about nine hundred and fifty only if one adopts his own reconciliations; tallies of this kind are reconstructions from genealogy, not muster rolls. (iv) A minimalist reading, which observes that the badri lists on the Muslim side are demonstrably swollen by later claimants and infers that the Meccan figure inflated in step, and would put the Meccan force nearer seven hundred. The minimalist case is respectable but it proves less than it claims: the direction of exaggeration in this literature runs toward magnifying the odds against the Muslims, so the Muslim figure of three hundred and thirteen — small, awkward, and not round — is unlikely to have been reduced, and there is no independent reason to think the Meccan figure was raised beyond what a Meccan muster could actually produce. Mecca and its confederates could field a thousand men; that they fielded between nine hundred and a thousand, less the Zuhra withdrawal, is what the earliest report says, and the only one that shows its working. The camel-count is the strongest single piece of evidence in the whole numerical question, because it is an inference from a fact a slave would have no reason to falsify, and it is not the sort of argument a later embellisher constructs. Hence "roughly nine hundred and fifty", stated as round and meant as round. See also §1 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 13)

30 On the hundred horses: Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of Badr, and Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids), give one hundred; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, has two hundred, and the higher figure is repeated by some later compilers. One hundred is preferable on two grounds: it is the earlier report, and two hundred cavalry against a force of nine hundred and fifty foot would be an extraordinary proportion for any Arabian army of the period, whereas one horse to nine or ten men is normal. The point is in any case nearly moot, since no source records the Meccan horse delivering a charge; see note 40. For the Muslim two horses and seventy camels, see note 20. al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, on the

drums, the wine and the singing-women; Ibn Ishaq preserves fragments of the satirical verse. The Muslim column, by contrast, moved without baggage, drums or women. See also §2 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 13)

31 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of Badr, gives the message in nearly these words; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, adds that the rider found the army at al-Juhfa. On the caravan's route west of Badr, both agree that it kept to the coast and passed the valley unseen. (p. 13)

32 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of Badr, for both the refusal and the three days at Badr; the same speech in al-Tabari, *Tarikh*, the year 2 AH. On the Nakhla affair and the killing of 'Amr ibn al-Hadrami in a sacred month, see Ibn Ishaq's account of the raid of 'Abdallah ibn Jahsh; the standing blood-claim it created is the single indispensable fact for understanding why the Meccan column did not go home. (p. 14)

33 Neither the road nor Meccan standing is a sufficient cause on its own, and the sources give the standing the greater weight: Abu Jahl's stated reason is what the Arabs would say, not what the caravans would cost. The economic reading — Watt's, and in a different form Donner's — is set out at note 6 and argued in the last section of this chapter. See also §16 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 14)

34 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of Badr, and Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids), on al-Akhnas and Banu Zuhra. How many men he took away is disputed: al-Waqidi's reckoning yields about a hundred, which is a plausible Zuhra contingent, while the tradition Ibn Ishaq transmits implies as many as three hundred, and the difference between the "thousand" that left Mecca and the "nine hundred and fifty" at Badr will not carry either figure. The safest statement is that Zuhra withdrew entire, that no man of them was at Badr, and that the withdrawal accounts for part but not all of the shrinkage of the column. That al-Akhnas was long remembered as the luckiest man in Quraysh suggests the number was large enough to notice. See also §1 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 14)

35 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of Badr, for 'Utba's speech from the red camel; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, is fuller and adds the offer to cover the caravan's costs as well as the blood-money. Whether the whole episode is a

piece of Rabi'a-family apologia, invented or polished by 'Utba's descendants to put their ancestor on the right side of a battle he lost, deserves to be taken seriously and should be rejected. Family tradition in this literature works by making a man look brave, or wise, or generous. It does not work by having him ride down his own line arguing for retreat, get called a coward by a rival to his face, fail to find a helmet that fits, and die in a duel he had tried to avoid. The proposal makes 'Utba look weak, and the material around it is unflattering in exactly the way invented material is not. It is also structurally necessary: something has to explain why an army that had begun to turn back turned round again, and 'Utba's failed offer explains it. Hakim ibn Hizam shuttled between them; Abu Jahl's insult is given in a coarser form in some recensions than I have rendered it. 'Utba's son Abu Hudhayfa ibn 'Utba was indeed in the Muslim ranks, and 'Utba's brother Shayba and his other son al-Walid were beside him; the kinship arithmetic of that one family is the battle in miniature. (p. 15)

36 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of Badr, for the exchange, quoted here from that version; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, has it with the cistern specified and the wells "filled in". The reply — that it was opinion and stratagem of war — is stable across the versions, and it is the load-bearing part. On whether the episode is historical: it has been suggested that al-Hubab's advice is a doublet, a later tradition that transferred to a named Ansari a judgement the Prophet had made himself, in the manner of other stories that supply a Companion as the human occasion for a decision. Two things tell against it. The first is that the story is theologically awkward — it has the Prophet halt in the wrong place and be corrected — and awkwardness of that kind is rarely manufactured. The second is that the tactical content is specific and correct: moving to the well nearest the enemy, disabling the rest, and building a cistern is exactly what a man who knew that ground would advise, and the arrangement is independently required by the position both armies are found in at dawn. The advice is historical in substance. Whether al-Hubab's precise words are his is another matter, and the wording does vary; what does not vary is the distinction he draws between revelation and judgement, which is why the exchange has been quoted so often since. See also §18 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 16)

37 al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, on the cistern (*hawd*) and the disabling of the surplus wells. Whether those wells were stopped up or merely held under guard is not certain — the verb in the reports can bear either sense, and "filled in" may be an intensification of "denied" — and the effect on the day was the same either way: an army that cannot reach a well is as thirsty as one whose well is choked. (p. 16)

38 The descent of al-ʿAqanqal is universally reported: Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of Badr, and al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, both have Quraysh come down from the sandhill into the valley. That no source records a cavalry charge at Badr, in a battle where one side had a hundred horses and the other two, is among the strongest confirmations that the ground was as the sources describe it. A horse taken down a thirty-degree slip-face in poor light arrives at the bottom in no condition to be ridden at a spear-line, and the belt of soft dune sand it would have had to cross to reach one was the worst going in the valley. See also §17 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 16)

39 The rain is in all the main accounts of the night: Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the night before Badr; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, who is the one who insists on its unequal effect on the two banks. The question is whether the differential is a genuine memory or an inference read backwards out of Q 8:11 ("and He sent down upon you water from the sky, to purify you ... and to make firm thereby your feet"), whose last clause invites exactly this gloss. Two things argue for a real squall. The first is the date: mid-March is the end of the Hijaz's brief wet season, and a night squall at Badr then is unremarkable rather than providential-looking. The second is that the effect the sources describe follows from the geology of the site independently of anyone's theology — the western bank at Badr is loose aeolian sand under the flank of al-ʿAqanqal, which slumps when wet, and the eastern floor is a gravel-and-silt wash which compacts. A storyteller inventing a miracle would not have arrived at so mechanical a benefit, and would probably have made the rain fall on one side only. The verse rests on the squall; the squall was not generated by the verse. The position is close to al-Mubarakpuri's, and does not require his confidence about quantities. See also §17 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 18)

40 Q 8:11. The sleep also appears at Q 3:154 in connection with Uhud, which is worth noticing: it is a recurring Qur'anic figure for a composure given from outside a man, not a detail generated for Badr. Ibn Ishaq narrates the drowsiness without the verse attached; the pairing is standard in the commentators. For the report itself, Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the night before Badr; and see also al-Tabari, *Tarikh*, the year 2 AH. (p. 18)

41 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the building of the 'arish; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, has the fullest version, including the saddled camels. Some later writers, uneasy at a proposal that contemplates defeat and flight, either drop the camels or transpose Sa'd's words into a pure declaration of loyalty. The uneasiness is itself evidence: material of this kind is not invented in a tradition that wants the day foreordained, and a later hand smoothing the record removes it rather than adding it. Whether the shelter had any other occupant than Abu Bakr is a minor question — al-Waqidi admits others to it at moments, every account keeps Abu Bakr there throughout. (p. 19)

42 Bukhari, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Maghazi, bab of the Badr expedition; also Muslim, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Jihad wa'l-Siyar, in the report of 'Umar ibn al-Khattab, which adds "O God, grant me what You have promised me" and, on the Prophet's coming out of the shelter, the words of Q 54:45 ("the host shall be routed"). Ibn Ishaq's version in the *Sira* is longer and more rhetorical, and al-Waqidi's longer still, with the appeal against Qurayshi pride and the request for the promised help fused into the night vigil rather than kept separate from it (note 49). The two-clause form in the two Sahih collections is the earliest layer and the one quoted here; the expansions are of the ordinary kind, in which a remembered petition acquires the cadence of liturgy. (p. 19)

43 17 Ramadan 2 AH is the majority date and the one used by Ibn Ishaq, al-Waqidi and Ibn Sa'd; al-Tabari records it and also preserves the variants of the nineteenth and the twenty-first, and a few reports put the battle on the twelfth. See Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids); al-Tabari, *Tarikh*, the year 2 AH. The conversion of 17 Ramadan 2 AH to 13 March 624 depends on the tabular Hijri calendar and on where one places the epoch, and is good to within a day or two rather than exactly. It does not by itself confirm the Friday: 13 March 624 in the Julian calendar was a Tuesday, and the

tradition's Friday is recovered only by allowing the two or three days of drift that an observational lunar calendar accumulates against an arithmetical one, which would put the day on 16 March. The Friday is independently and repeatedly attested and is not derived from any calculation; the arithmetic is what has to give. This is set out in the headnote to the Chronology below. Readers should hold the day of the month more loosely than the season, which is secure: everything in the accounts — the rain, the state of the wells, the caravan's timing — belongs to early spring. See also §11 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 19)

44 Ibn Ishaq has the army fasting; a group of reports in al-Waqidi and in the hadith collections on the traveller's fast has the Prophet ordering the fast broken before contact, and the Companions' later disagreement about fasting on campaign is often argued from Badr in both directions. Bukhari, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Sawm, has material for the licence; Muslim, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Siyam, likewise. The licence-reports mostly concern the march to Mecca in 8 AH, and their attachment to Badr looks like backward extension. Since the contact came in the first hour after sunrise, the practical difference is small in any case: fasting or not, these men had eaten nothing since the previous sunset and had marched and dug for two days before that. (p. 19)

45 al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr; Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids), in the notice of Sawad ibn Ghaziyya. The name is given as Sawad ibn Ghaziyya of the Banu 'Adi ibn al-Najjar; some manuscripts have Suwayd. The story is of a type — the reciprocal-justice anecdote — and that makes it suspect as an anecdote while leaving the arrow-shaft, which is corroborated independently as the instrument with which the ranks were dressed, entirely secure. (p. 20)

46 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the morning of Badr; al-Waqidi is fuller and gives more names. The marking of the fall-places is one of the elements the tradition treats as foreknowledge, and it is reported here as the tradition reports it. What can be said in the historian's own voice is narrower and still interesting: that men of the Muslim army afterwards remembered particular deaths as having happened on particular patches of a valley floor they had spent a day and a night looking at, and that the memory took this shape. (p. 20)

47 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the morning of Badr. The second supplication, made as the Qurayshi line formed up, is distinct in Ibn Ishaq from the

night vigil; al-Waqidi runs them together, and Ibn Kathir, *al-Bidaya wa'l-Nihaya*, iii, sets the versions side by side without choosing. I keep them separate because the two petitions do different work — one asks for the promise, the other names the men across the wadi — and because a fused version is the easier direction of travel. (p. 21)

48 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the fighting at Badr; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, who gives the oath in direct speech and the detail of the crawl into the basin. Al-Aswad ibn 'Abd al-Asad was of Makhzum, Abu Jahl's clan. That the first death of the day was over drinking water, on the edge of the field and outside the formal opening of the battle, is the kind of detail a shaped narrative loses rather than gains. (p. 21)

49 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the single combats; and see Ibn Kathir, *al-Bidaya wa'l-Nihaya*, iii. A second family of reports has the Rabi'a brothers challenge and the three Hashimites answer directly, with no Ansari intervention at all, and it is easy to see why that version might be preferred by a later transmitter: it is tidier, and it spares the Ansar a refusal. The Ansari-first sequence is preferable precisely because it costs something. It also explains the shape of the Qurayshi demand, which is not merely for champions but for peers — a demand about rank and lineage, made by men who would not be killed by farmers of Yathrib, and which only makes sense as an answer to somebody. Al-Waqidi keeps the three Ansar and names them as here; the identification of the two sons of 'Afra as 'Awf and Mu'awwidh is his, and Mu'awwidh reappears later in the day at Abu Jahl's side. See also §13 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 22)

50 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the single combats, for the words about Abu Talib and the Prophet's laying 'Ubayda's head on his foot; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, for the severed leg and the marrow. On where he died the reports differ between al-Safra' on the return road, which Ibn Ishaq implies and which most later writers follow, and Medina some days after the army got back; al-Safra' is the better attested and is followed here. 'Ubayda ibn al-Harith ibn al-Muttalib was a first cousin once removed of the Prophet and something over sixty years old, which makes the pairing against 'Utba a matter of matching age and standing rather than of matching strength. (p. 22)

51 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the battle of Badr; the wording is close to "if they press close about you, then shoot, and do not draw your swords upon them until they are upon you." Whether this is genuine tactical memory or a later reconstruction deserves a word. It is the kind of detail a pious redactor would not invent: it makes the day begin with the smaller army standing still and shooting rather than charging in faith, and it gives the credit to ground and discipline. It also matches the equipment (note 20): an army with eight swords in it had every reason to keep its distance as long as it could and to make the enemy come through arrow-fire across bad footing. I take the order as substantially historical, while granting that its exact wording has been smoothed. Al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, gives a fuller set of orders in the same sense. (p. 23)

52 al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr; Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids). Mihja' is named as the first of the Muslims killed at Badr in most lists, though a minority of reports give that place to Harith ibn Suraqa; both appear in "The Fourteen" above. Al-Waqidi's detail that Harith was hit while drinking at the cistern is the sort of circumstantial touch that makes him valuable and unverifiable in the same breath. (p. 23)

53 The figures are argued at note 20 and are not re-argued here; what matters when the lines close is the consequence, which the sources themselves draw. Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the muster for Badr, and Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids), give six coats of mail and eight swords among three hundred and thirteen men. At Badr the Muslims fought principally with bows, spears and stones, and particular weapons are recorded as individually notable in a way that would be absurd if there had been two hundred swords in the ranks. Al-Waqidi's slightly higher counts of mail may reflect equipment taken from the Qurayshi dead being read back into the muster. Abu Dujana's red headcloth, which some retellings place here, belongs to Uhud: al-Waqidi has him wear it at Badr as well, but the story of the marked man who takes the Prophet's own sword and vows not to bring it back is an Uhud episode throughout the earlier material, and it is not used in this chapter. (p. 23)

54 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the battle of Badr; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, where the handful is thrown at the moment the general advance is ordered. The Arabic of the cry is *shahat al-wujuh*, "disfigured be the faces." Q 8:17 — "you

did not slay them, but God slew them; and you did not throw when you threw, but God threw" — was read by the early exegetes as referring to this act, and al-Tabari, *Tarikh*, the year 2 AH, records that reading along with one that applies the verse to the killing generally. The report is given here as the tradition gives it and is not adjudicated: what can be said in a historian's voice is that a hot wind carrying dust off a dry valley floor into the faces of men advancing westward with the morning sun behind their opponents is a thing that happens at Badr in March, and that the tradition, which had no interest in a naturalistic reading, nonetheless preserved the physical detail of eyes and mouths full of grit. (p. 24)

55 Q 8:9 for the thousand; Q 8:12 for the words quoted, from which this section takes its title. Al 'Imran gives different figures in a passage the exegetes connect with Badr: three thousand at Q 3:124 and five thousand at Q 3:125, the latter conditional on the believers' steadfastness. The three sets of numbers have been harmonised in various ways since the second century — a thousand promised and sent, three thousand promised on condition, five thousand on a further condition; or a thousand at Badr and the larger figures belonging to Uhud, where Q 3:121–129 otherwise sits. I follow the reading that treats Q 8:9 as the figure operative at Badr and the Al 'Imran verses as a fuller promise whose occasion the tradition itself is unsure of, since the Anfal material is the earliest layer and is unambiguously about this day. Ibn Kathir, *al-Bidaya wa'l-Nihaya*, iii, sets out the harmonisations at length and is candid that the exegetes did not agree. See also §12 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 24)

56 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the battle of Badr, for the man of the Banu Mazin ibn al-Najjar; Muslim, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Jihad wa'l-Siyar, for the version from Ibn 'Abbas, in which the Ansari sees the head of the man before him fall as the voice cries out. Hayzum is named in these reports as the horse of Jibril. Bukhari, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Maghazi, bab of the Badr expedition, preserves a report from Ibn 'Abbas of the Prophet's supplication in the shelter and the answer to it, but not the horseman; the horseman comes through the Medinan maghazi tradition and through Muslim. (p. 24)

57 al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, is the fullest collector of these reports; the yellow-turban material, in which the angels came down wearing turbans of the

same colour as al-Zubayr's, appears there and is repeated by Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids). The growth is worth watching in sequence. The Qur'anic layer names no angel and describes no combat, only help, a token, and a command. Ibn Ishaq's layer adds Jibril, a named horse, a voice, and men who heard rather than saw. Al-Waqidi and after him the later compilers add numbers, positions in the line, headgear, and named angelic combatants; by the time of the popular sira literature the angels have biographies. That trajectory — from allusion to specification over roughly two centuries — is the ordinary behaviour of this material and is the reason the chapter reports the earliest layer, attributes the middle layer, and mentions the latest only as a growth. (p. 25)

58 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the battle of Badr; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, where the blade is named al-'Awn and its descent in 'Ukkasha's family is noted. 'Ukkasha ibn Mihsan was killed fighting Tulayha al-Asadi in the ridda campaigns after the Prophet's death. The survival of the sword as a family heirloom is the mechanism by which such a report reaches the collectors: the object authenticates the story and the story authenticates the object, and the historian can say confidently only that the family of 'Ukkasha possessed a sword they said was this one. (p. 25)

59 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the battle of Badr, where the account of the leg and the arm is given on Mu'adh's own authority, including the comparison of the severed leg to a date-stone shot from under the crusher. On who brought Abu Jahl down, the tradition offers three claims and one composite. (i) Bukhari, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Maghazi, bab of the Badr expedition, has the Prophet ask who will find out what became of Abu Jahl, and 'Abdallah ibn Mas'ud find him dying and take his head; Bukhari also carries a report in which two young men of the Ansar — sons of 'Afra, in that version — are named as having killed him, and the Prophet, examining their swords, judges that one of them struck the fatal blow. (ii) Ibn Ishaq gives the sequence followed here: Mu'adh ibn 'Amr ibn al-Jamuh takes the leg, 'Ikrima cuts Mu'adh's arm, Mu'awwidh ibn 'Afra strikes the fallen man and dies later in the fight, and Ibn Mas'ud finishes him. (iii) Al-Waqidi and some of the Ansari family traditions promote Mu'adh ibn 'Afra, brother of Mu'awwidh, to the leg-strike, which looks like a Banu 'Afra claim competing with a Banu Salima one; the two Mu'adhs are easily confused and the confusion is old. I follow Ibn Ishaq because his

sequence is the only one that accounts for all the surviving details — Mu'adh ibn al-Jamuh's arm, 'Ikrima's presence, Mu'awwidh's death deep in the enemy line, and Ibn Mas'ud's head — without discarding any of them, and because the competing versions are each traceable to an interested clan while the composite is not. The Prophet's inspection of the two swords, in the Bukhari report, is itself evidence that the question of credit was disputed on the field that afternoon. See also §5 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 26)

60 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the battle of Badr, for the whole episode, the shout, and 'Abd al-Rahman's remark about his prisoners and his armour; Bukhari, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Maghazi, bab of the Badr expedition, preserves the account from 'Abd al-Rahman ibn 'Awf, including that the two men had a compact of protection between them from before the hijra. The report is unflattering to Bilal, to the Ansar and to the discipline of the victorious army, and no later hand tidied it; that is a good sign of its age. See also §7 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 27)

61 Al-Baladhuri and the exegetical tradition on Q 58:22 both preserve the report; Ibn Kathir, *al-Bidaya wa'l-Nihaya*, iii, records it with a note of hesitation, since other reports have al-Jarrah surviving Badr. The doubt is worth registering: the kinship material at Badr attracted illustrative accretion precisely because it was theologically useful, and Abu 'Ubayda's case is the weakest of the set. 'Umar and al-'As ibn Hisham, and Abu Hudhayfa and his father, are on much firmer ground, both being in Ibn Ishaq. (p. 27)

62 The exchange between Abu Bakr and his son 'Abd al-Rahman is preserved in the biographical tradition, Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, iii (the Badr companions), and repeated by Ibn Kathir, *al-Bidaya wa'l-Nihaya*, iii. It is placed by some at Badr and by others at Uhud; the point of the story is the same in either setting. (p. 27)

63 Bukhari, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Maghazi, bab of the Badr expedition, for the exchange and for "you have climbed high, little shepherd" — the taunt turns on Ibn Mas'ud having herded goats for 'Uqba ibn Abi Mu'ayt in Mecca; Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the battle of Badr, for the request to strike high at the neck, and for the words over the head, "this was the Pharaoh of this community." Al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, adds that Abu Jahl's regret was to have been killed by a farmer rather than by a man of standing — a variant which, whether or not it is his,

is exactly the sentiment the whole battle was about. Whether the Prophet himself fought hand to hand at Badr is a related question, and the answer is probably not: he directed the line from the rise and moved forward with it, and the reports of his throwing dust and pebbles and calling men on are unanimous, but no early source has him exchanging blows, and Ibn Ishaq, who names the killer of nearly every Qurayshi of rank, credits him with none. Al-Waqidi's fuller picture of him in the press is best read as devotional emphasis on presence rather than as a claim about swordplay. (p. 28)

64 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the burial of the Quraysh dead at Badr; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr. The word used is *qalib*, an unlined water-pit or a well that has lost its lining — not a grave and not a cistern, and the distinction matters, because it tells us the dead of Quraysh were disposed of in a hole that already existed. Al-Waqidi has the bodies dragged by work parties and covered over; Bukhari's material on the episode, in Kitab al-Maghazi, bab of the killing of Abu Jahl and the following babs, refers to the pit as already there. (p. 29)

65 Bukhari, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Maghazi, bab of the killing of Abu Jahl, and Kitab al-Jana'iz; Muslim, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Janna, on the dead of Badr in the pit; Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the same passage. The two families of report differ in wording: Ibn Ishaq has the Prophet call the dead by name and ask whether they have found what their lord promised true, and has him say that God had promised him victory over them; Bukhari's version is shorter and turns on the exchange with 'Umar. 'A'isha objected to the report on doctrinal grounds, holding that what the Prophet said was "they now know that what I used to tell them was the truth," and citing Q 27:80 and 35:22, that the dead cannot be made to hear. Her objection is preserved in Bukhari and in Muslim and is worth keeping precisely because it is early: it shows a first-generation Muslim scholar arguing about the theology of a report inside living memory of the event, which is the strongest evidence we have that the transmitters were not simply inventing. Ibn Kathir, *al-Bidaya wa'l-Nihaya*, iii, canvasses the versions and prefers the fuller one; the chapter reports both and adjudicates neither. See also §18 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 29)

66 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the lists of the Quraysh slain and of the prisoners at Badr, and the list of the Muslim dead, gives seventy killed and seventy taken; al-

Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, names his dead and prisoners clan by clan and the totals recoverable from his lists fall a little short of seventy in each column, as do those in Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids). Q 3:165 and 8:67 are consistent with heavy Meccan losses but give no figures. The candid position: seventy is a traditional round number of the kind Arabic historiography reaches for, and the name-lists were compiled later and are demonstrably incomplete, so what can be said is that something on the order of sixty to eighty Meccans were killed and a comparable number taken. On the Muslim side the fourteen — six Muhajirun, eight Ansar — is the figure of Ibn Ishaq and of most later writers; al-Waqidi's lists and some of Ibn Sa'd's material push towards twenty-two by including men who died later of wounds, among them 'Ubayda ibn al-Harith, buried at al-Safra' on the road home. Fourteen is the count of the men left in the ground at Badr, and this chapter uses it in that sense. See also §9 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 29)

67 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of Abu Hudhayfa at the pit; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, adds the detail of 'Utba's weight and of the party stalling in the sand. The Rabi'a-family material at Badr — 'Utba's attempt at peace, his son's grief, his daughter Hind's later hatred — is unusually full, and one might suspect a family tradition; but the reports as they stand do not flatter 'Utba, and a family shaping its own memory does not leave its patriarch heavy, doubted and dragged. (p. 30)

68 Q 8:1 for the spoils and Q 8:41 for the fifth; Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the division of the spoils of Badr; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, is the fullest on the three claimant parties and on the appointment of 'Abdallah ibn Ka'b al-Mazini; Bukhari, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Khums. The animal figures — a hundred and fifty camels and ten horses — are al-Waqidi's and are round; they are also, at roughly a fifth of the Meccan train, plausible for what a beaten army abandons. On the equal share and the shares of the absent-on-duty and of the dead, Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids). Watt, *Muhammad at Medina*, ch. 7, treats the Badr division as the origin of the later law of *ghanima*, and the sequence in the sources supports him: an improvised ruling on a field, later generalised. (p. 30)

69 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the march back from Badr and the killing of al-Nadr ibn al-Harith; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr. Ibn

Ishaq names ʿAli as the executioner; a minority of reports leaves the man unnamed or gives al-Miqdad ibn ʿAmr, who had claimed al-Nadr as his own prisoner and, in one report, complained of losing the ransom. The Rustam and Isfandiyar material — al-Nadr competing with the Qur'an by reciting Persian romance — belongs to the Meccan chapters of Ibn Ishaq and to the commentary tradition on Q 31:6 and 83:13; it is given here because it explains why he was singled out. (p. 31)

70 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the killing of ʿUqba ibn Abi Mu'ayt at ʿIrq al-Zabya, names ʿAsim ibn Thabit al-Ansari, and this is the report the chapter follows: it is the earliest, and it keeps the two executions distinct in place, date and executioner, which a later harmoniser would have had no motive to do. A well-attested variant gives ʿAli ibn Abi Talib for both men, and it is easy to see how that came about — ʿAli's name at al-Safra' drawing ʿUqba's death to it as well, with some assistance from later Shi'i and proto-Shi'i emphasis on ʿAli's role at Badr. Al-Waqidi and al-Tabari, *Tarikh*, the year 2 AH, both carry the doubling. The exchange over ʿUqba's sons, and the answer "the Fire," is Ibn Ishaq's; some later writers omit it, and it is not hard to see why. See also §6 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 31)

71 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the sending of the two heralds; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, has ʿAbdallah ibn Rawaha to the upper town and Zayd ibn Haritha to the lower on al-Qaswa'. Al-Waqidi also preserves the report that Ruqayya, the Prophet's daughter, was buried in Medina on the day Zayd rode in. (p. 31)

72 Muslim, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Jihad wa'l-Siyar, the bab on the prisoners of Badr, preserves the long report in ʿUmar's own voice, including the proposal that each man be given his own kinsman to kill; Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, and al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, both carry the Abu Bakr / ʿUmar exchange, al-Waqidi with more speakers, including ʿAbdallah ibn Rawaha, who is made to propose burning the prisoners in a fire. The shape of the story is suspiciously good: two counsellors, mercy against severity, the Prophet choosing mercy and revelation siding with severity. That is how a tradition remembers an argument, not how an argument happens. What is likely historical is that there was a real dispute in the camp and on the road, that ransom was the outcome, that it was thought afterwards to have been the wrong outcome, and that the positions were later sorted into the two men who

had come to stand for leniency and rigour in the community's memory of itself. The chapter accordingly gives the debate as the sources give it and marks the tidiness rather than pretending to see behind it. (p. 32)

73 Q 8:67–69. On the connection of these verses to the ransom, see the commentary tradition summarised in Ibn Kathir, *al-Bidaya wa'l-Nihaya*, iii, and his *al-Sira al-Nabawiyya*; the report of the Prophet and 'Umar weeping is in Muslim, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Jihad wa'l-Siyar. The rebuke is early: a community shaping its memory freely does not invent a revelation criticising its founder's judgement, and Q 8:67–69 is one of the strongest internal arguments for the Qur'an as the oldest layer of the Badr material. See also §16 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 32)

74 On the graded ransoms, al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, and Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids); the top rate of 4,000 dirhams and the bottom of a thousand are al-Waqidi's, with intermediate rates by clan. Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, has the release without ransom of Abu 'Azza the poet and of al-Muttalib ibn Hantab. The teaching arrangement — a literate prisoner freed for teaching ten boys of Medina to write — is reported by Ibn Sa'd and by al-Baladhuri, and Zayd ibn Thabit is named among the pupils; the report is late enough to warrant caution about the round ten, but the practice fits an unlettered town that had just acquired seventy educated Meccans and no money to buy anything else with. On Suhayl ibn 'Amr and the teeth, Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, and Ibn Kathir, *al-Bidaya wa'l-Nihaya*, iii; the saying that Suhayl might yet take a stand that would please the Prophet is read by later writers against his speech at Mecca on the day the Prophet died, and the report may have been shaped to fit it. See also §15 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 32)

75 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of al-'Abbas's capture and ransom; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, on the gold left with Umm al-Fadl; Bukhari, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Maghazi, bab of the Badr expedition, and Kitab al-Khums, for the ransom of al-'Abbas along with 'Aqil ibn Abi Talib, Nawfal ibn al-Harith and his ally 'Utba ibn 'Amr. Three positions circulate in the sources. The first, which this chapter takes, is that he came out with the Quraysh as a Hashimite of standing did, fought or at least stood in their line, was taken, and was ransomed on the same terms as anyone of his rank. The second is that he was brought out under compulsion,

unwilling, and that the Prophet had told his men before the battle not to kill him. The third is that he had been a Muslim in secret since before Badr and had been sending word from Mecca. The second and third grew in the telling, and it is not difficult to see whose interest they served: the ʿAbbasid caliphs traced their claim through this man, and it was intolerable to their apologists that the ancestor should have stood against the Prophet with a sword. Against them stands the ransom itself, exacted in full and with the ledger of hidden gold produced against him; and the answer he is given in the earliest report — that if what he says is true God will reward him for it, but that outwardly he was against them — is precisely the sentence a later apologist would not have needed to preserve. The instruction not to kill him is likely enough as a kinsman's instruction; that is a different thing from compulsion. See also Watt, *Muhammad at Medina*, on the shaping of Hashimite and ʿAbbasid material in the sira. See also §8 of "What the Sources Disagree About" above. (p. 33)

76 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the news reaching Mecca, is the source for al-Haysuman ibn ʿAbdallah, for Safwan in the Hijr, for Abu Lahab at Zamzam, for Abu Sufyan ibn al-Harith's report of men in white on piebald horses, and for Umm al-Fadl and the tent-pole; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, adds detail on Abu Lahab's death from *al-ʿadasa*, the "lentil" pustule the Meccans took for plague, and on the stoning of the body from a distance. On the prohibition of public mourning and on al-Aswad ibn al-Muttalib's blindness and the woman weeping for her camel, Ibn Ishaq again; the anecdote is the kind of thing that survives because it was told as a poem's occasion, and al-Aswad's verses on his sons are quoted by Ibn Hisham in the same place. (p. 34)

77 Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of the raid on the caravan of Quraysh; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, which is the fuller on the caravan's coastal detour and its arrival. No source gives the sale itself in detail, and the profit is inference from the fact of arrival; the caravan is nowhere reported lost, and Abu Sufyan is in Mecca and active there within days. (p. 35)

78 Ibn Ishaq, in Guillaume, *The Life of Muhammad*, 309, for the reception on the road and the instruction that the prisoners be well used; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, book of Badr, adds the boys running out and names some of them. Al-Rawha' lies

roughly a long day's march south of Medina on the Badr road; the figure in the Arabic sources is given in *barid* and stages rather than miles. (p. 35)

79 The clan affiliations are drawn from Ibn Ishaq's list of the Quraysh dead, clan by clan (Ibn Hisham, *Sira*, the naming of those killed at Badr), checked against Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids). Al-Waqidi's list is shorter in places and differs in a handful of names; the discrepancies fall among the junior dead and do not touch the senior men. Whether Badr can carry the interpretative weight later tradition placed on it is a fair question, and the honest answer is that it can carry this much and not much more: the loss of these particular men is documented in lists compiled independently of the battle narratives, in genealogical and *nasab* material whose interest was in descent rather than in edification. The claim that Mecca's leading generation died at Badr is thus better attested than almost anything in the battle itself. The larger claims — that Badr broke Meccan paganism, or that it was the decisive engagement of Arabian history — are theological verdicts, and the fact that Mecca fought on for six more years and beat the Muslims badly at Uhud is the check on them. (p. 36)

80 W. Montgomery Watt, *Muhammad at Medina*, on the Meccan trade and the strategy of the raids; the argument runs through his account of the years 1–3 AH. Watt's economic reading has been criticised on two grounds. Fred M. Donner, "Mecca's Food Supplies and Muhammad's Boycott," argues that the traffic at issue was less grand and more local than the Watt picture implies — grain and food as much as luxury transit — which if anything strengthens the case that interference with it was intolerable. The other objection is that Watt's frame leaves too little room for what the participants said they were doing; the sources are unembarrassed about religion as a cause, and a reading that treats the religious language as a covering for the commercial one is making a choice the evidence does not compel. The position taken here is that the road was the occasion of the war and the seniority of Quraysh was the casualty of it. (p. 37)

81 For Abu Sufyan's oath and the raid of al-Sawiq, and for Safwan ibn Umayya, see al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, the raids following Badr; Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids). Hind bint 'Utba's part at Uhud is in Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the account of

Uhud, and in al-Waqidi; her mutilation of Hamza's body is among the more luridly developed episodes in the tradition and is not needed for the point made here. (p. 37)

82 For the expulsion of the Banu Qaynuqa' in Shawwal 2 AH see Ibn Ishaq (Ibn Hisham), *Sira*, the affair of Banu Qaynuqa'; al-Waqidi, *Kitab al-Maghazi*, the raid on Banu Qaynuqa'; Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, ii (the raids). The sequence of causes there is genuinely disputed and is not argued in this chapter. (p. 37)

83 Q 8:1 on the spoils; Q 8:41 for the fifth and for the phrase *yawm al-furqan*; Q 8:67–69 on the prisoners; Q 8:5–7 for the "other of the two parties"; Q 8:9–12 and 8:17 for the sleep, the rain, the angels and the dust. The identification of *al-furqan* in 8:41 with the day of Badr is the standard exegetical reading and is as old as the earliest commentaries, but it is a reading and not a statement: the verse says "the day of the *furqan*, the day the two hosts met," and the gloss depends on taking the second clause as defining the first, which is natural but not inevitable, since *furqan* elsewhere in the Qur'an denotes revelation itself rather than an event. The chapter follows the traditional identification because the immediate context is manifestly the division of spoils after a battle. On the *khums* as dated to Badr, see the fiscal chapters of the legal literature and al-Baladhuri on the early division of spoils; the jurists are unanimous that the rule of the fifth begins here. (p. 38)

84 Ibn Sa'd, *Tabaqat*, iii, arranges his biographies so that the Badr participants come first and are marked as such, which is the clearest evidence of the rank's institutional weight; for 'Umar's stipends see al-Baladhuri on the pensions. Bukhari, *Sahih*, Kitab al-Maghazi, bab of the Badr expedition, preserves the report of Hatib ibn Abi Balta'a, whom the Prophet excused a serious breach on the ground that he had been at Badr. On the lists: the surviving rosters of the three hundred and thirteen were assembled well over a century after the day, and they are longer than they should be. Al-Waqidi and Ibn Sa'd both name men whose presence other authorities deny, and the direction of error is predictable, since descent from a *badri* was worth money and standing under the Umayyads and worth more under the 'Abbasids. The names of the dead are the most secure part of the record; the names of the survivors are the least. (p. 38)

85 On the sources generally, see "A Note on the Sources" above. The specific point about duels is worth isolating: al-Waqidi's Badr is organised to a striking degree

around single combats with named participants on both sides, and the *maghazi* — the literature of the raids — had by his time acquired an audience for exactly that. Ibn Ishaq's account, a generation earlier, is looser and less complete, and where the two differ the direction of growth is almost always from vagueness towards circumstantial detail rather than the reverse. This is the single most useful rule of thumb a reader of Badr can carry. (p. 38)